Cambridge IGCSE Literature in English 0475 · Paper 2 Drama

The Importance of Being Earnest

Oscar Wilde · A revision guide

For examination in 2028, 2029 and 2030

Event bank · Quote bank · Theme arcs by act and across the play

Past questions · Self-test

Contents

1. How to use this guide 3
2. The examination 4
3. Context 5
4. The play at a glance 7
5. Event bank 8
6. Characters 13
7. Themes 16
8. Theme and act grid 20
9. Wilde's methods 21
10. Quote bank 23
11. Past questions 35
12. Self-test 51
13. Glossary 53
14. Sources 54

How to use this guide

Every event, claim and quotation in this guide is tied to the play. References take the form I.202: Act I, line 202, where each line of dialogue counts as one line, however long. A stage direction is referenced to the line it follows, for example I.274 s.d.. Lines are counted from the start of each act in the Project Gutenberg text of the play (eBook #844), the three-act version used by most school editions. Act I has 301 lines of dialogue, Act II has 397 and Act III has 181.

Your own edition will have page numbers rather than line numbers, so each reference sits beside a description of the moment. Use the line number to judge position: II.300 is about three-quarters of the way through Act II.

> **Two ways to read the banks.** The event bank, quote bank and theme arcs can be read *by act*, for revising a single section of the play, or *as a whole arc*, for essay questions that range across the play. Each theme section ends with a one-line summary of its arc and the numbers of the quotations that track it through Acts I, II and III.

The examination

Syllabus	Cambridge IGCSE Literature in English 0475, syllabus for 2028, 2029 and 2030. The play is a set text for Paper 2 Section A (Drama) in all three years (pp. 13, 16, 19). It does not appear in the 2027 syllabus.
Paper	Paper 2 Drama and Unseen (Open text): 2 hours, 50 marks, 50% of the qualification. Candidates answer one question from Section A (Drama) and one from Section B (Unseen), each worth 25 marks (pp. 9, 22).
Choice on this play	Two questions: one passage-based, with the passage printed on the paper, and one essay question (pp. 9, 22).
Open text	You may take your copy into the exam. Highlighting, underlining and brief handwritten notes in words and phrases are allowed; sticky notes, inserted paper and extended notes are not (pp. 20, 23).
Assessment objectives	AO1 knowledge of the text supported by reference; AO2 understanding of meanings, contexts, ideas and attitudes; AO3 analysis of how the writer uses language, structure and form; AO4 an informed personal response. Each is weighted equally and all are tested in every question (p. 10, p. 22).
Command words	"Explore" means write in detail about particular aspects. Questions may also begin "How does the writer…", "In what ways…", "How far…" or "To what extent…" (p. 31).
Coursework route	Candidates taking Component 3 instead of Paper 2 may use a Paper 2 play in their comparative essay; the syllabus's own example title compares social class in *An Inspector Calls* and this play (p. 24).

About the past questions in this guide. The past questions in Section 10 come from earlier papers in the 0486 series (2013), which used the same passage-based and essay pattern as the 2028–30 Paper 2. Each passage is printed in full, from the text used in this guide; the papers used a different edition, so you may see small differences such as "one's self" for "oneself".

Context

Facts about Wilde and the first production come from published study guides, each one named. Facts about the play come from the play.

The first performance

The cast list printed with the play records the first production at the St James's Theatre, London, on 14 February 1895, with George Alexander (also the theatre's manager) as John Worthing.

Source: Play text, front matter (cast list)

Writing and revision

Wilde wrote the play in the summer of 1894 at Worthing, the seaside town that gives Jack his surname. It was first written in four acts; at Alexander's request it was cut to three by omitting "the Gribsby episode" and merging two acts into one.

Source: LitCharts, Key Facts p. 1; CliffsNotes, "About the play" and Wilde biography

The play inside its own world

Jack himself explains that Worthing is "a place in Sussex . . . a seaside resort" I.205, the scene list sets the action in "TIME: The Present", and Lady Bracknell measures time by the London season I.216.

Source: Play text (front matter and Act I)

Aestheticism

Wilde was associated with the Aesthetic movement and its idea of "art for art's sake", learned partly from Walter Pater at Oxford. The play's preference for style over sincerity III.19 can be read in this light.

Source: LitCharts, Brief Biography p. 1

Genre: farce, comedy of manners and melodrama

Wilde borrowed from French farce and the "well-made play", with their mistaken identities, lost children and secrets from the past, and from the Victorian comedy of manners. The guides describe the play as a mixture of satire, comedy of manners and farce.

Source: SparkNotes, Context; CliffsNotes, "About the play"

The dandy

The dandy, a witty, carefully dressed figure who speaks in epigrams and mocks moral cant, is a recurring Wilde type. Algernon is the clearest example in this play.

Source: SparkNotes, Context and Motifs

Scandal and trial

On 28 February 1895, two weeks after the opening, the Marquess of Queensberry left a card at Wilde's club accusing him of "posing as a sodomite" (misspelled). Wilde sued for libel and lost, was then prosecuted for gross indecency under the Criminal Law Amendment Act of 1885, convicted and sentenced to two years' hard labour. The production was withdrawn. Sources give different figures for the length of the first run, so the guide does not state one.

Source: CliffsNotes, "Disaster and Ruin"; SparkNotes, Context; LitCharts, Historical Context

Later readings

SparkNotes notes that the play was long seen as purely frivolous, and that later critics have read its double lives and talk of "wickedness" as a coded commentary on secrecy and hypocrisy. This is an interpretation, not a fact about Wilde's intention, and should be presented as such in an answer.

Source: SparkNotes, Context

Context inside the play

Context earns credit when it explains something in the text. These references to the play's own world are the most useful ones to know.

Liberal Unionists	Lady Bracknell: "they count as Tories" I.200. The party split from the Liberals over Irish Home Rule and sided with the Conservatives; her line shows what she cares about is the alliance.
The Morning Post	Where Gwendolen's engagement "will appear" II.289: society announcements as public proof.
Mudie and the three-volume novel	Cecily's lending-library novels II.12; Miss Prism's own manuscript is one III.126.
The Season	Lady Bracknell wants a parent produced "before the season is quite over" I.216: the London social calendar of balls and matches.
The Funds	Cecily's money is "in the Funds" III.70: safe government stock, hence its instant appeal.
Court Guides and Army Lists	Printed directories of Society and of officers III.64 III.170: the establishment's own records decide identity.
University Extension Scheme	Lord Bracknell supposedly attends a lecture "on the Influence of a permanent income on Thought" III.44: a joke on adult education and on money.
Grosvenor Square and Belgrave Square	Fashionable addresses I.184 I.191; the "unfashionable side" matters to Lady Bracknell.

The play at a glance

Act	Setting	Events	Event titles
Act I	Algernon's flat, Half-Moon Street, London	E1–E11	Algernon and Lane: piano, champagne and marriage; "Ernest" arrives in town; The cigarette case; Jack's explanation; Bunbury and Bunburying; Lady Bracknell and Gwendolen arrive; Jack's proposal; The interview; After the interview; Gwendolen returns; Algernon plans to go Bunburying
Act II	The garden, the Manor House, Woolton	E12–E23	The garden: Cecily, Miss Prism and Dr Chasuble; Algernon arrives as "Ernest"; Miss Prism and Chasuble on marriage; Jack in mourning; The brothers "reconciled"; Jack orders Algernon away; Algernon's proposal and Cecily's diary; Gwendolen meets Cecily; The tea-table quarrel; The double exposure; Jack admits there is no Ernest; The muffin quarrel
Act III	Drawing-room (morning-room in the stage direction), the Manor House, Woolton	E24–E31	Explanations accepted; Lady Bracknell arrives; Bunbury dies; Lady Bracknell examines Cecily; Deadlock; The christenings cancelled; Miss Prism named; "Prism! Where is that baby?"; The hand-bag and the mistaken mother; The name in the Army Lists

The plot in brief

Act I. In his London flat Algernon uses a cigarette case to discover that his friend "Ernest" is called Jack in the country, where he is guardian to Cecily I.71, and reveals his own invented invalid, Bunbury I.88. Jack proposes to Gwendolen, who loves him for his name I.153. Lady Bracknell forbids the match when she learns Jack was found in a hand-bag I.218. Algernon secretly notes Jack's country address I.274 s.d..

Act II. At Jack's house in Hertfordshire Algernon arrives as Jack's wicked brother Ernest II.42 and proposes to Cecily, who has imagined their engagement for months II.210. Jack arrives in mourning for the brother who is in the dining-room II.88 s.d.. Gwendolen arrives; the two women find they are both engaged to "Ernest" II.289, and both deceptions are exposed II.349. Each man has arranged to be christened Ernest II.385.

Act III. The women forgive the men on condition that they are christened III.29. Lady Bracknell accepts Algernon's engagement to Cecily once she hears of Cecily's fortune III.77, but Jack will not consent unless he may marry Gwendolen III.105. A chance mention of Miss Prism reveals that Jack is the baby she lost in a hand-bag twenty-eight years before III.126: Lady Bracknell's nephew, Algernon's elder brother III.153, christened Ernest John after his father III.170.

The play's own list of scenes gives the three settings; Act III's stage direction calls the room a "Morning-room" III, opening s.d.. The action covers two days. Act I ends with Algernon planning to go Bunburying "To-morrow" I.288; in Act II Gwendolen dates Jack's proposal to "yesterday afternoon" II.291; Act III continues the same afternoon III.91. Act II is set in July II, opening s.d..

Event bank

Thirty-one numbered events in order. Read one act for close revision, or read E1 to E31 straight through as the arc of the whole play.

Act I

E1 Algernon and Lane: piano, champagne and marriage I.1–17

Algernon boasts that he plays with "wonderful expression" rather than accuracy, queries the eight bottles of champagne recorded in Lane's book, and receives Lane's deadpan account of his own marriage. Alone, he complains that the "lower orders" fail to set a good example I.17.

Why it matters. The first exchange sets the play's method: master and servant trade composed inversions, and moral responsibility is assigned to the class least able to enforce it.

E2 "Ernest" arrives in town I.18–52

Lane announces "Mr. Ernest Worthing" I.18. Jack says he has come up to town to propose to Gwendolen I.36. Algernon guards the cucumber sandwiches while eating them himself I.41 and refuses consent until Jack explains "the whole question of Cecily" I.51.

Why it matters. The audience meets Jack under the false name first, so the play opens inside the deception it will later resolve.

E3 The cigarette case I.53–78

The inscription "From little Cecily, with her fondest love to her dear Uncle Jack" exposes Jack's second name I.68. He first claims Cecily is his aunt in Tunbridge Wells I.63 and then admits he is "Ernest in town and Jack in the country" I.71.

Why it matters. A private object becomes public evidence; the first of several written texts in the play (case, card, diary, Army List) that expose or confirm identity.

E4 Jack's explanation I.79–83

Jack explains that Thomas Cardew adopted him and made him guardian to Cecily, who lives in the country with Miss Prism I.79. To escape the "high moral tone" required of a guardian, he invented a younger brother, Ernest, who lives in the Albany I.83.

Why it matters. Respectability is presented as the cause of deception rather than its opposite.

E5 Bunbury and Bunburying I.84–102

Algernon reveals his own fiction, "an invaluable permanent invalid called Bunbury", used to escape to the country and to avoid dining with his aunt I.88. Jack resolves to "kill" his brother if Gwendolen accepts him I.93.

Why it matters. The two men are established as mirror images: one escapes to town, the other to the country.

E6 Lady Bracknell and Gwendolen arrive I.103–132

The plate of cucumber sandwiches is empty, though the audience has watched Algernon eat from it I.41. He picks up the plate "in horror" I.115 and Lane supports him with the claim that there were "no cucumbers in the market" I.116. Algernon cites a telegram about Bunbury's illness to escape dinner I.127, prompting Lady Bracknell's view that Bunbury should decide "whether he was going to live or to die" I.130.

Why it matters. Lane's lie in support of his master quietly shows deception running through both classes.

E7 Jack's proposal I.134–167

Gwendolen confesses that her ideal "has always been to love some one of the name of Ernest" I.141, dismisses the name Jack I.153, and directs the proposal herself, announcing in advance that she will accept I.159.

Why it matters. Romance is conducted as performance and rehearsal; the woman controls the scene that convention gives to the man.

E8 The interview I.168–218

Lady Bracknell forbids the engagement I.172 and questions Jack from her list of "eligible young men" on smoking, age, income, property, politics and parents I.178. Jack reveals that he was found in a hand-bag in the cloak-room at Victoria Station I.211. She advises him to "acquire some relations" I.216 and refuses to let her daughter "marry into a cloak-room, and form an alliance with a parcel" I.218.

Why it matters. The central obstacle of the plot is set: Jack has no family, and therefore no place in Society.

E9 After the interview I.219–264

Algernon plays the Wedding March I.219. Jack calls Lady Bracknell a Gorgon I.221 and plans to kill Ernest off with "a severe chill" in Paris I.245. He lets slip that Cecily is "excessively pretty" and "only just eighteen" I.249.

Why it matters. Jack supplies the very information that sends Algernon to the country.

E10 Gwendolen returns I.266–284

Gwendolen declares her "eternal devotion" whatever her mother does I.271 and asks for Jack's country address. Algernon writes it on his shirt-cuff I.274 s.d..

Why it matters. A silent piece of stage business plants the next act.

E11 Algernon plans to go Bunburying I.286–301

Algernon tears up letters that appear to be bills I.285 s.d. and announces that he is going Bunburying the next day I.288. The act ends with him reading his shirt-cuff and smiling I.301 s.d..

Why it matters. The act closes on a visual cue that the audience understands and Jack does not: dramatic irony carries the plot into Act II.

Act II

E12 The garden: Cecily, Miss Prism and Dr Chasuble II.1–34

Miss Prism tries to teach Cecily German II.1. Cecily defends her diary II.10, and Miss Prism mentions the three-volume novel she once wrote, whose manuscript "was abandoned" II.17. Dr Chasuble calls and the two go for a walk.

Why it matters. The lost manuscript is a plant for Act III, delivered as a passing joke.

E13 Algernon arrives as "Ernest" II.35–80

Algernon presents Jack's card II.36 and meets Cecily, who expects her "wicked cousin Ernest" II.42. She tells him Jack plans to send him to Australia II.58 and pins a pink rose in his buttonhole II.77.

Why it matters. Algernon steps into the fiction Jack created; the card that proved Jack was "Ernest" in Act I now lets someone else become him.

E14 Miss Prism and Chasuble on marriage II.81–87

Miss Prism urges Chasuble to marry II.81, and both cover their double meanings by explaining their metaphors II.87.

Why it matters. A comic subplot of desire hidden under propriety, resolved in the final embrace.

E15 Jack in mourning II.88–128

Jack enters in full mourning II.88 s.d. and announces that Ernest has died in Paris of a severe chill II.106. He arranges with Chasuble to be christened at half-past five II.126.

Why it matters. Jack's fiction and Algernon's are about to collide; the audience knows "Ernest" is in the dining-room.

E16 The brothers "reconciled" II.129–158

Cecily produces "your brother Ernest" II.134. Jack refuses Algernon's hand until Cecily threatens never to forgive him II.149.

Why it matters. A visual climax of dramatic irony: two men who know the truth act out a reconciliation for an audience on stage who do not.

E17 Jack orders Algernon away II.159–184

Merriman reports that "Mr. Ernest's" luggage has been unpacked II.164. Jack orders the dog-cart; Algernon mocks the mourning clothes II.176.

Why it matters. The quarrel is fought through costume and luggage, the props of farce.

E18 Algernon's proposal and Cecily's diary II.185–248

Cecily takes down Algernon's declaration as dictation II.199. She reveals they have been engaged for three months II.210, that she wrote his letters herself II.220, and that she broke off and renewed the engagement in her diary II.224. She too must marry an Ernest II.234. Algernon leaves to arrange a christening II.243.

Why it matters. Cecily is the author of her own romance; the man she accepts has been written in advance.

E19 Gwendolen meets Cecily II.249–297

The two women declare instant friendship II.257, but Gwendolen grows wary on learning Cecily is Mr Worthing's ward II.279. Each then claims to be engaged to Ernest Worthing, with diaries as evidence II.291.

Why it matters. The parallel proposals of Act I and Act II now meet in a single misunderstanding.

E20 The tea-table quarrel II.298–319

With servants present, the rivals fight through politeness II.297 s.d.. Gwendolen refuses sugar and cake as unfashionable II.312; Cecily gives her both II.312.

Why it matters. Manners become weapons: the quarrel is conducted entirely through the rituals of afternoon tea.

E21 The double exposure II.320–346

Each woman identifies the other's fiancé by his real name II.325 II.336. The women embrace as allies II.337 and call each other sister II.346.

Why it matters. The scene is built on exact repetition, each line answered by its mirror image. Jack's Act I prediction that the women would call each other sister is fulfilled I.251.

E22 Jack admits there is no Ernest II.347–357

Asked where his brother Ernest is, Jack admits he has none II.349, and the women withdraw into the house II.357 s.d..

Why it matters. The first time Jack is "forced to speak the truth", and it ruins both engagements.

E23 The muffin quarrel II.358–397

Algernon eats muffins calmly "because I am unhappy" II.377. Both men reveal they have arranged to be christened Ernest II.385. The act ends with Algernon still eating II.397.

Why it matters. The act ends on appetite rather than resolution, mirroring the cucumber sandwiches of Act I.

Act III

E24 Explanations accepted III.1–39

The women resolve on "a dignified silence" III.7 and break it at once. They accept the men's explanations for their "beauty" rather than their truth III.18, but the names remain "an insuperable barrier" until the men promise to be christened III.29.

Why it matters. Gwendolen states the play's governing principle: "style, not sincerity" III.19.

E25 Lady Bracknell arrives; Bunbury dies III.40–56

Lady Bracknell has followed Gwendolen "by a luggage train" III.44 and forbids all communication with Jack III.44. Algernon announces that Bunbury is dead, "quite exploded" III.53.

Why it matters. Algernon's fiction is killed off as Jack's was, completing the parallel.

E26 Lady Bracknell examines Cecily III.57–86

Lady Bracknell questions Cecily's origins III.61. Jack lists addresses, solicitors and certificates; only the news of "a hundred and thirty thousand pounds in the Funds" changes her mind III.70. She approves the match III.77.

Why it matters. The interview of Act I is replayed with the roles reversed: this time Jack holds the information.

E27 Deadlock III.87–108

Jack refuses consent as Cecily's guardian, citing Algernon's untruthfulness III.89, and reveals that under her grandfather's will Cecily does not come of age until thirty-five III.97. He offers a bargain: his consent for Lady Bracknell's III.105. She refuses III.106.

Why it matters. The comic plot reaches complete stalemate; only an external revelation can free it.

E28 The christenings cancelled; Miss Prism named III.109–124

Lady Bracknell forbids Algernon's baptism III.112 and Jack withdraws III.114. Chasuble mentions that Miss Prism is waiting in the vestry, and Lady Bracknell reacts at once III.116.

Why it matters. The chance mention of a name triggers the recognition plot.

E29 "Prism! Where is that baby?" III.125–133

Lady Bracknell recalls that twenty-eight years earlier Prism left Lord Bracknell's house with a baby boy and never returned; the perambulator held only a three-volume novel III.126. Miss Prism explains that she put the manuscript in the basinette and the baby in the hand-bag III.127, which she left at Victoria, the Brighton line III.133.

Why it matters. Act I's comic interview details (hand-bag, cloak-room, Brighton line) turn out to be the exact evidence of identity.

E30 The hand-bag and the mistaken mother III.134–155

After noise offstage III.137 s.d., Jack produces the hand-bag, which Miss Prism identifies by its marks III.145. Jack embraces her as his mother III.148; she redirects him to Lady Bracknell, who reveals he is the son of her sister, Mrs Moncrieff, and Algernon's elder brother III.153.

Why it matters. The melodramatic recognition is parodied through a false start before the true one.

E31 The name in the Army Lists III.156–181

Gwendolen will not change her decision on names III.158. Lady Bracknell confirms Jack was christened after his father III.163; the Army Lists give the General's Christian names as "Ernest John" III.170. Three couples embrace III.176, and Jack delivers the title line III.181.

Why it matters. Jack's invented name proves to be his real one: the lie turns into the truth without anyone having to become sincere.

Characters

Jack Worthing (John; "Ernest" in town)

Guardian of Cecily, listed in the cast as "John Worthing, J.P." (Justice of the Peace), owner of the Manor House at Woolton; the foundling whose origin drives the plot.

- Leads a double life, justified by the "high moral tone" a guardian must adopt I.83.
- Sincere in love but evasive about truth, which he thinks unsuitable for "a nice, sweet, refined girl" I.237.
- Often irritable and earnest in manner: he loathes listening, talking and looking I.257 I.259, and stages his brother's death in full mourning II.88 s.d..
- Gains power in Act III as guardian, withholding consent III.87, then loses all composure in his search for his name III.170.

Arc. From inventor of a fiction (Act I) to its victim (Act II) to its unwitting fulfilment (Act III).

Algernon Moncrieff

Lady Bracknell's nephew, a London bachelor and dandy; inventor of Bunbury.

- Speaks almost entirely in epigrams and inversions I.84 I.228.
- Defined by appetite: cucumber sandwiches in Act I I.41 and muffins in Act II II.377.
- Financially insecure, tearing up bills I.285 s.d.; Lady Bracknell admits he "has nothing to depend upon" but debts III.77.
- Falls in love with Cecily at once II.184 and, unlike Jack, is frank about putting pleasure before duty II.172.

Arc. From cynic about marriage (Act I) to eager fiancé (Act II) to the younger brother of the man he mocked (Act III).

Lady Bracknell (Aunt Augusta)

Gwendolen's mother and Algernon's aunt; the play's gatekeeper of Society and its main obstacle.

- Speaks in confident, balanced epigrams that make prejudice sound like reason I.202.
- Treats marriage as a transaction recorded in a notebook I.178 and changes her view of Cecily as soon as money is mentioned III.71.
- Fears disorder from below: education, revolution and "social legislation" I.184 III.54.
- Herself married up without fortune III.77, and keeps her husband deceived as a matter of principle III.44.
- Holds the knowledge that resolves the plot III.126.

Arc. Obstacle in Act I, intruder in Act III, and finally the agent of recognition.

Gwendolen Fairfax

Lady Bracknell's daughter, engaged to Jack.

- Determined and self-assured: she accepts Jack before he proposes I.159 and claims never to be wrong I.137.
- Loves the name Ernest more than the man I.153.
- Shares her mother's snobbery and use of the lorgnette at the tea table II.269 II.297.
- Values performance in life: style over sincerity III.19, and suspense for its own sake III.143.

Arc. Moves from rebelling against her mother's control (Act I) to rivalry and alliance with Cecily (Act II) to marriage on her own terms (Act III). A useful exam question asks how far she resembles her mother (see the past-paper bank).

Cecily Cardew

Jack's ward, eighteen, an heiress living in the country under Miss Prism's care.

- Dislikes her lessons and prefers her diary II.34 II.10.
- Fascinated by wickedness II.40.
- Invents her own romance, including the engagement, the ring and the letters II.216.
- As sharp as Gwendolen in combat II.312, and impatient of waiting III.101.

Arc. The innocent country girl Jack describes in Act I I.247 proves the most inventive character in the play.

Miss Prism

Cecily's governess; author of the lost three-volume novel.

- Stern moraliser II.9 with a hidden romantic interest in Chasuble II.81.
- Her past is planted in Act II II.17 and revealed in Act III III.127.
- Mistaken by Jack for his unmarried mother III.148.

Arc. From comic moralist to the source of the plot's resolution.

Canon Chasuble, D.D.

The local rector.

- Hides feeling behind learned phrasing II.26.
- Satirised through his all-purpose sermon II.110 and his unpublished sermons against the Anabaptists III.115.
- Accepts the christenings without question and is united with Miss Prism at the end III.176.

Arc. A minor comic figure whose casual mention of Miss Prism triggers the recognition III.115.

Lane and Merriman

Algernon's manservant (town) and Jack's butler (country).

- Lane is impassive and witty, and covers for his master's greed I.116.
- Merriman's announcements structure entrances and exits II.35 III.40.
- The presence of servants restrains the quarrelling women II.297 s.d..

Arc. Silent witnesses to upper-class behaviour, used for timing and irony.

Themes

Each theme is traced through the three acts. Quotation numbers refer to the quote bank in Section 9.

Identity, names and the double life

Every main character in the play is defined by a name, and most of them are wrong about it. Jack is Ernest in town and Jack in the country I.71; Algernon invents Bunbury I.88; both women love a name rather than a man I.141 II.234. The comic question of who someone is turns out to be a question about family and status, and it is answered by documents rather than by character.

Act I	Act I sets up the double life. The cigarette case exposes Jack's second name I.68, Algernon names the practice "Bunburying" I.86, and Lady Bracknell reveals the cost of having no origin: Jack, found in a hand-bag, has no place in Society I.218. Quotations: Q4, Q8, Q9, Q10, Q12, Q18, Q19, Q20, Q28, Q29, Q30
Act II	In Act II the fictions multiply and collide. Algernon becomes "Ernest" using Jack's own card II.36; Jack arrives in mourning for a brother who is in the dining-room II.88 s.d.; and the double exposure strips both men of the name the women love II.338 II.341. Quotations: Q45, Q54, Q60
Act III	Act III resolves identity through records. The hand-bag, the Army Lists and Lady Bracknell's memory establish that Jack is Ernest John Moncrieff, Algernon's elder brother III.153 III.170. Jack learns that the name he invented was true all along III.173. Quotations: Q77, Q82, Q94, Q96, Q101, Q104, Q107

The whole arc. Across the play, identity moves from invention (Act I) to confusion (Act II) to documentary proof (Act III). The lie becomes the truth without anyone choosing to be honest.

Marriage, courtship and romance

Marriage drives the plot and is discussed in almost every scene. It is treated as a business arrangement by Lady Bracknell, as a romantic fiction by the young women, and as something to escape by Algernon in Act I.

Act I	Act I opens with Lane's account of his "misunderstanding" I.12 and Algernon's cynicism I.41. Gwendolen stage-manages Jack's proposal I.159, and Lady Bracknell turns it into an interview from her list of eligible men I.178. Quotations: Q2, Q5, Q6, Q13, Q15, Q18, Q19, Q21, Q22, Q23, Q24, Q32
Act II	Act II gives a second proposal that parodies the first: Cecily has already conducted the whole engagement in her diary II.210. Miss Prism courts Chasuble through talk of matrimony II.81, and the two engagements collide at the tea table II.289. Quotations: Q47, Q48, Q49, Q56, Q57, Q58, Q59, Q60
Act III	In Act III marriage becomes a negotiation over money and consent. Cecily's fortune wins Lady Bracknell's approval III.71, Jack trades consent for consent III.105, and three couples embrace once the obstacles are removed III.179. Quotations: Q80, Q84, Q88, Q89, Q93, Q103, Q105

The whole arc. The play moves from talk about marriage to the mechanics of arranging it. Romance is real but always expressed through conventions: proposals rehearsed, diaries kept, consents bargained.

Class, money and Society

The characters are almost all wealthy, and Wilde satirises the values that keep them so: birth, property, fashion and the exclusion of outsiders. Servants are present throughout and often more composed than their employers.

Act I	Act I sets out the rules. Algernon expects the "lower orders" to set an example I.17, and Lady Bracknell judges Jack by income, property, the fashionable side of Belgrave Square and his politics I.196 I.200. She fears education as a threat to the upper classes I.184. Quotations: Q2, Q3, Q17, Q24, Q25, Q26, Q27, Q28, Q31, Q32
Act II	In Act II class appears in manners and snobbery. Gwendolen's spade insult and her contempt for the country II.297 II.306 are answered by Cecily through the rituals of tea, conducted in front of servants II.297 s.d.. Quotations: Q53, Q64, Q65, Q66, Q67, Q68
Act III	Act III replays the interview with Cecily as its subject. Addresses, solicitors and certificates matter less than her fortune III.71; Lady Bracknell reveals that she married without fortune herself III.77; and Jack's status is secured only when he is proved a Moncrieff III.153. Quotations: Q82, Q83, Q84, Q85, Q86, Q87, Q88, Q90, Q91, Q97, Q98, Q102

The whole arc. The same test is applied twice, to Jack in Act I and to Cecily in Act III. Each passes only when the right family or the right money is found.

Morality: earnestness, sincerity and hypocrisy

The title's pun sets the problem: being earnest (serious, sincere) is the great Victorian virtue, yet every character who claims it is performing. Wilde reverses the vocabulary so that the trivial is treated seriously and the serious trivially.

Act I	In Act I Jack explains that respectability itself drove him to deceive I.83, while Algernon insists on seriousness about meals I.102. Morality appears as a public tone rather than a private conviction. Quotations: Q1, Q3, Q7, Q8, Q10, Q11, Q12, Q14, Q16, Q17, Q22, Q35, Q37
Act II	Act II exposes moral rhetoric. Miss Prism's severity II.9 and Chasuble's adaptable sermon II.110 are comic, and Cecily defines hypocrisy as pretending to be wicked II.44. Algernon declares he is "serious about Bunburying" II.363. Quotations: Q38, Q39, Q42, Q44, Q45, Q50, Q52, Q53, Q70, Q71, Q72, Q73
Act III	In Act III Gwendolen states the principle outright III.19. The plot rewards Jack for a truth he never intended III.173, and the final line turns the pun on itself III.181. Quotations: Q74, Q75, Q76, Q80, Q85, Q90, Q91, Q104, Q106, Q107

The whole arc. The play opens with a boast about expression over accuracy I.3 and ends with a man earnest by accident. Sincerity never wins anything; style and luck do.

Gender and inversion

Victorian gender roles are frequently reversed. Women run the courtships and set the terms; men eat in a crisis, present a christening as an act of courage and are managed. The two young women begin as rivals and end as allies.

Act I	In Act I Gwendolen directs Jack's proposal I.163 and Lady Bracknell takes the interviewing role usually given to a father, who is mentioned only as an invalid figure I.172. Algernon's epigram on mothers and sons I.228 frames the question of inheritance. Quotations: Q21, Q23, Q33, Q34, Q35, Q36
Act II	In Act II Cecily writes her own romance II.220, Gwendolen treats the home as the man's sphere II.267, and the rivals unite against the men II.337. Quotations: Q38, Q48, Q49, Q62, Q63, Q67, Q69
Act III	In Act III the women decide the terms of forgiveness III.29 and mock male "self-sacrifice" III.35. Jack names the sexual double standard, but to forgive a sin that never happened III.150. Quotations: Q78, Q79, Q92, Q100

The whole arc. Power in the play sits with the women, above all Lady Bracknell, while the men's deceptions are discovered and judged by them.

Fiction, writing and truth

Writing and fiction recur as objects: a cigarette case inscription, visiting cards, Cecily's diary and letters, Miss Prism's three-volume novel, the Army Lists. Characters treat life as if it were a novel, and the plot borrows openly from melodrama.

Act I	Act I turns on reading what one should not I.60. The cigarette case and the card are written evidence I.70, and Algernon secretly writes Jack's address on his cuff I.274 s.d.. Quotations: Q7, Q11
Act II	Act II centres on Cecily's diary, a record of events that never happened II.12 written "for publication" II.199. Miss Prism's formula for fiction II.15 and her lost manuscript II.17 prepare Act III. Quotations: Q40, Q41, Q42, Q43, Q55, Q56, Q57, Q58, Q61
Act III	In Act III the manuscript explains the baby III.127, Lady Bracknell jokes about coincidence III.137, and the truth is finally found in a printed book III.170. Quotations: Q75, Q95, Q96, Q97, Q99

The whole arc. Writing first conceals (Act I), then invents (Act II), and finally reveals (Act III). The play ends happily, as Miss Prism says fiction should.

Religion, death and ritual

Death, illness and the sacraments are treated as social business. Bunbury's illnesses, Ernest's invented death and the double christening make the solemn rituals of Victorian life into plot devices.

Act I	In Act I Lady Bracknell finds a widow rejuvenated I.111, treats health as a duty I.130 and demands that Bunbury decide whether to live or die. Jack and Algernon choose a cause of death for Ernest as if picking a menu I.242. Quotations: Q6, Q15, Q16
Act II	In Act II Jack performs mourning II.88 s.d., Miss Prism moralises over the dead II.100, and both men arrange to be christened Ernest II.116 II.385. Quotations: Q39, Q46, Q50, Q51, Q52, Q54
Act III	In Act III Bunbury dies "under proper medical advice" III.56, Lady Bracknell forbids the christenings as excess III.112, and christening turns out to have been one of the luxuries lavished on the infant Jack III.161. Quotations: Q81, Q100, Q102

The whole arc. Rituals of death and baptism are used to change identity, and by the end both are unnecessary: no one dies and no one is christened.

Theme and act grid

Find quotations for any theme in any act. Reading a row from left to right gives that theme's arc.

Theme	Act I	Act II	Act III
Identity, names and the double life	Q4, Q8, Q9, Q10, Q12, Q18, Q19, Q20, Q28, Q29, Q30	Q45, Q54, Q60	Q77, Q82, Q94, Q96, Q101, Q104, Q107
Marriage, courtship and romance	Q2, Q5, Q6, Q13, Q15, Q18, Q19, Q21, Q22, Q23, Q24, Q32	Q47, Q48, Q49, Q56, Q57, Q58, Q59, Q60	Q80, Q84, Q88, Q89, Q93, Q103, Q105
Class, money and Society	Q2, Q3, Q17, Q24, Q25, Q26, Q27, Q28, Q31, Q32	Q53, Q64, Q65, Q66, Q67, Q68	Q82, Q83, Q84, Q85, Q86, Q87, Q88, Q90, Q91, Q97, Q98, Q102
Morality: earnestness, sincerity and hypocrisy	Q1, Q3, Q7, Q8, Q10, Q11, Q12, Q14, Q16, Q17, Q22, Q35, Q37	Q38, Q39, Q42, Q44, Q45, Q50, Q52, Q53, Q70, Q71, Q72, Q73	Q74, Q75, Q76, Q80, Q85, Q90, Q91, Q104, Q106, Q107
Gender and inversion	Q21, Q23, Q33, Q34, Q35, Q36	Q38, Q48, Q49, Q62, Q63, Q67, Q69	Q78, Q79, Q92, Q100
Fiction, writing and truth	Q7, Q11	Q40, Q41, Q42, Q43, Q55, Q56, Q57, Q58, Q61	Q75, Q95, Q96, Q97, Q99
Religion, death and ritual	Q6, Q15, Q16	Q39, Q46, Q50, Q51, Q52, Q54	Q81, Q100, Q102

Wilde’s methods

AO3 asks how the writer creates meanings and effects through language, structure and form. In a play, form includes what an audience sees and hears.

Epigram and paradox

Short, balanced, quotable sentences that state a surprising general truth, often by reversing a familiar idea I.84 III.140. Comment on the balance (antithesis), the turn on the final word, and what the line reveals about the speaker.

Inversion

Expected values are turned upside down: the servants should set a moral example I.17, being found is worse than losing parents, truth is a thing to apologise for III.173.

The pun on Ernest / earnest

First voiced by Algernon I.70 and completed in the last line III.181. Discuss both meanings: the name and the moral quality.

Parallel and mirrored scenes

Structure is built on repetition: two invented people (Ernest and Bunbury), two proposals (Act I and Act II), two interviews by Lady Bracknell (Jack in Act I, Cecily in Act III), two christenings booked, two women who say the same lines II.324 II.335. Mirroring makes the action feel mechanical, which is one source of farce.

Stichomythia and rapid exchange

Short alternating lines build pace and comic rhythm, as in the tea-table duel II.311–313 and the women’s rehearsed silence III.7–11.

Stage directions and physical comedy

Wilde’s directions carry jokes that dialogue does not: Algernon writing on his cuff I.274 s.d., Jack’s mourning dress II.88 s.d., Cecily’s four lumps of sugar, trunks being thrown about offstage III.137 s.d.. In a drama answer, always comment on what an audience would see.

Dramatic irony

The audience knows more than the characters, especially in Act II: Cecily warns against a double life to a man living one II.44, and Jack mourns a brother who is in the dining-room II.132.

Melodrama conventions parodied

Lost babies, a mysterious hand-bag, the governess with a past, a mistaken mother and a revelation from a book are stock devices of Victorian melodrama. Wilde uses them straight-faced and lets characters remark on them III.137.

Structure and time

Three acts, three settings (the flat in Half-Moon Street; the garden and then the drawing-room at Woolton) I, opening s.d.. The action is compressed into two days: Jack proposes "yesterday afternoon at 5.30", according to Gwendolen on the second day II.291, and Act III follows the same afternoon III.91.

Asides and choral speech

Gwendolen's aside lets the audience hear what politeness hides II.310; the women and men speak in unison III.29 III.30, turning dialogue into a duet.

Motifs and symbols

Food

Cucumber sandwiches and bread and butter (Act I) I.41, sugar, cake and tea (Act II, first half) II.314, muffins and tea-cake (Act II, close) II.393. Food stands in for desire, rivalry and selfishness, and lets characters fight without saying what they mean.

The hand-bag and the railway

Mentioned as a comic absurdity I.207, mocked as an origin III.61, then produced as proof III.143. Victoria Station and the Brighton line are repeated word for word in both acts I.213 III.133.

Diaries, cards and documents

The card proves Jack is "Ernest" in Act I I.70 and introduces Algernon as Ernest in Act II; the diaries supply rival claims II.291; the Army Lists settle the name III.170.

Mourning and christening

Clothes and ceremonies mark changes of identity that never quite happen: Jack's mourning for an invented death, two christenings arranged and cancelled III.113.

The garden and the town

Jack's town/country division I.24 is mapped onto the settings. The country garden "full of roses" II, opening s.d. is not innocent: it is where the most elaborate fictions are played out.

Quote bank

107 quotations, in order of appearance, each checked against the text. Theme tags link them to Sections 6 and 7.

Act I

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q1	I.3	**Algernon:** "I don't play accurately—any one can play accurately—but I play with wonderful expression." The play's first boast prizes manner over correctness. The dash-enclosed aside dismisses accuracy as something anyone can manage, so style becomes the mark of distinction. Morality
Q2	I.12	**Lane:** "I have only been married once. That was in consequence of a misunderstanding between myself and a young person." Lane delivers the first joke about marriage in the same composed register as his master; the servant's wit matches the gentleman's, which unsettles the class hierarchy the dialogue assumes. Marriage Class
Q3	I.17	**Algernon:** "Really, if the lower orders don't set us a good example, what on earth is the use of them?" An inversion: the upper class expects moral leadership from those beneath it. The rhetorical question exposes a privilege that sees other people only in terms of their "use". Class Morality
Q4	I.24	**Jack:** "When one is in town one amuses oneself. When one is in the country one amuses other people." Balanced sentences set town against country, the geography of the double life. The impersonal "one" turns a private evasion into a social rule. Identity
Q5	I.39	**Algernon:** "The very essence of romance is uncertainty." Algernon separates romance from marriage. His view is reversed in Act II, where Cecily has removed all uncertainty by settling the engagement in advance. Marriage
Q6	I.41	**Algernon:** "Divorces are made in Heaven" One word changed in the proverb "marriages are made in heaven" turns piety into cynicism, a model of Wilde's inverted commonplace. Marriage Religion
Q7	I.60	**Algernon:** "More than half of modern culture depends on what one shouldn't read." Spoken as he reads the private inscription on the cigarette case; the forbidden text drives both culture and the plot. Fiction Morality

Q8	I.70	**Algernon:** "You answer to the name of Ernest. You look as if your name was Ernest. You are the most earnest-looking person I ever saw in my life." The first sounding of the pun on which the title rests. Name and character are assumed to match, a premise the whole play tests. Identity · Morality
Q9	I.71	**Jack:** "my name is Ernest in town and Jack in the country" A neat summary of the double life: identity changes with location, as if a name were a suit of clothes. Identity
Q10	I.83	**Jack:** "When one is placed in the position of guardian, one has to adopt a very high moral tone on all subjects." "Adopt" presents morality as a role put on for others. Jack's respectability is the reason he needs a fictional brother. Morality · Identity
Q11	I.84	**Algernon:** "The truth is rarely pure and never simple." Algernon takes Jack's cliché "pure and simple" and turns it into a paradox about truth itself. Morality · Fiction
Q12	I.88	**Algernon:** "I have invented an invaluable permanent invalid called Bunbury, in order that I may be able to go down into the country whenever I choose." The parallel structure with Jack's "useful younger brother" makes the two men mirror images. Both inventions are excuses for pleasure dressed as duty. Identity · Morality
Q13	I.96	**Algernon:** "You don't seem to realise, that in married life three is company and two is none." Another proverb reversed ("two's company, three's a crowd"), suggesting that marriage survives only through deception. Marriage
Q14	I.102	**Algernon:** "I hate people who are not serious about meals. It is so shallow of them." Seriousness is applied to the trivial, and "shallow" to people who neglect it: the play's scale of values turned upside down. Morality
Q15	I.111	**Lady Bracknell:** "I never saw a woman so altered; she looks quite twenty years younger." Widowhood rejuvenates. In her first long speech Lady Bracknell treats a husband's death as an improvement. Marriage · Religion
Q16	I.130	**Lady Bracknell:** "Health is the primary duty of life." Duty, the great Victorian virtue, is attached to something no one controls, which makes illness a moral failing and Bunbury a social offender. Morality · Religion

Q17	I.132	**Lady Bracknell:** "French songs I cannot possibly allow. People always seem to think that they are improper, and either look shocked, which is vulgar, or laugh, which is worse." What matters is not whether the songs are improper but how people react; her morality is a matter of public appearance. Class · Morality
Q18	I.141	**Gwendolen:** "my ideal has always been to love some one of the name of Ernest. There is something in that name that inspires absolute confidence." Gwendolen loves a name rather than a man. The "confidence" the name inspires is misplaced, since Jack has invented it. Identity · Marriage
Q19	I.149	**Gwendolen:** "that is clearly a metaphysical speculation, and like most metaphysical speculations has very little reference at all to the actual facts of real life, as we know them." The one question that matters, whether she could love him under another name, is dismissed as philosophy. Dramatic irony: the audience knows it is a practical question. Identity · Marriage
Q20	I.153	**Gwendolen:** "The only really safe name is Ernest." A name chosen for safety and the absence of risk, which is exactly what Jack's double life has been designed to avoid. Identity
Q21	I.159	**Gwendolen:** "I think it only fair to tell you quite frankly before-hand that I am fully determined to accept you." Gwendolen takes charge of the proposal and removes its suspense; the formal register of "fully determined" makes courtship sound like business. Gender and inversion · Marriage
Q22	I.167	**Gwendolen:** "I hope you will always look at me just like that, especially when there are other people present." Romantic feeling is valued as a public display. Marriage · Morality
Q23	I.172	**Lady Bracknell:** "An engagement should come on a young girl as a surprise, pleasant or unpleasant, as the case may be. It is hardly a matter that she could be allowed to arrange for herself" Marriage is arranged by parents; the daughter's feelings are irrelevant. "Pleasant or unpleasant" concedes that happiness is a matter of chance. Marriage · Gender and inversion
Q24	I.178	**Lady Bracknell:** "you are not down on my list of eligible young men, although I have the same list as the dear Duchess of Bolton has" The marriage market is run like an office, with shared lists and an interview. Marriage · Class

Q25	I.184	**Lady Bracknell:** "Ignorance is like a delicate exotic fruit; touch it and the bloom is gone." An elegant simile in praise of ignorance. The imagery of delicacy makes stupidity sound like a precious possession. Class
Q26	I.184	**Lady Bracknell:** "If it did, it would prove a serious danger to the upper classes, and probably lead to acts of violence in Grosvenor Square." Lady Bracknell admits openly that the upper classes depend on others remaining uneducated. Class
Q27	I.188	**Lady Bracknell:** "It gives one position, and prevents one from keeping it up." Land brings status but costs money; the antithesis shows that her class runs on appearances it can barely afford. Class
Q28	I.202	**Lady Bracknell:** "To lose one parent, Mr. Worthing, may be regarded as a misfortune; to lose both looks like carelessness." The play's most famous line treats bereavement as a lapse in good management. The balanced clauses make the cruelty sound reasonable. Identity Class
Q29	I.203	**Jack:** "It would be nearer the truth to say that my parents seem to have lost me . . . I don't actually know who I am by birth." Jack's lack of origin is the plot's central problem. "Who I am by birth" defines identity by family, the assumption Act III will satisfy. Identity
Q30	I.209	**Jack:** "I was in a hand-bag—a somewhat large, black leather hand-bag, with handles to it—an ordinary hand-bag in fact." The comic precision of the description is later the evidence that identifies the bag in Act III. Identity
Q31	I.214	**Lady Bracknell:** "seems to me to display a contempt for the ordinary decencies of family life that reminds one of the worst excesses of the French Revolution" A trivial accident is linked with revolution: her exaggeration reveals an upper class fearful of disorder from below. Class
Q32	I.218	**Lady Bracknell:** "to marry into a cloak-room, and form an alliance with a parcel?" Jack is reduced to luggage. "Alliance" shows that marriage, for her, is a contract between families. Class Marriage
Q33	I.221	**Jack:** "In any case, she is a monster, without being a myth, which is rather unfair" Jack's Gorgon comparison makes Lady Bracknell a figure of terror, yet his joke is as polished as hers. Gender and inversion

Q34	I.228	**Algernon:** "All women become like their mothers. That is their tragedy. No man does. That's his." A symmetrical epigram on gender; Jack's "Is that clever?" invites the audience to judge the wit as well as enjoy it. Gender and inversion
Q35	I.237	**Jack:** "My dear fellow, the truth isn't quite the sort of thing one tells to a nice, sweet, refined girl." Women are protected from truth, an attitude that the women of Act II, with their diaries and decisions, show to be naive. Morality · Gender and inversion
Q36	I.271	**Gwendolen:** "Few parents nowadays pay any regard to what their children say to them. The old-fashioned respect for the young is fast dying out." A complaint about the young reversed: Gwendolen speaks as though the parents were the disobedient ones. Gender and inversion
Q37	I.299	**Algernon:** "I love scrapes. They are the only things that are never serious." Trouble is valued for its lightness; Algernon sums up his own philosophy just before going in search of one. Morality

Act II

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q38	II.2	**Cecily:** "But I don't like German. It isn't at all a becoming language. I know perfectly well that I look quite plain after my German lesson." Education is judged by its effect on appearance, an early sign that Cecily shares the values of the town. Gender and inversion · Morality
Q39	II.9	**Miss Prism:** "I am not in favour of this modern mania for turning bad people into good people at a moment's notice. As a man sows so let him reap." Miss Prism's biblical severity is comic because her own past, revealed in Act III, needs exactly the forgiveness she refuses. Morality · Religion
Q40	II.11	**Miss Prism:** "Memory, my dear Cecily, is the diary that we all carry about with us." A sententious metaphor, deflated at once by Cecily's reply. Fiction
Q41	II.12	**Cecily:** "Yes, but it usually chronicles the things that have never happened, and couldn't possibly have happened." Cecily treats memory as fiction, which is exactly what her own diary turns out to be. Fiction

Q42	**II.15**	**Miss Prism:** "The good ended happily, and the bad unhappily. That is what Fiction means." The moral formula of melodrama, which the play mocks while following it to a happy ending. Fiction · Morality
Q43	**II.17**	**Miss Prism:** "The manuscript unfortunately was abandoned." Cecily's start and Miss Prism's correction ("lost or mislaid") plant the lost manuscript that will explain the lost baby. Fiction
Q44	**II.40**	**Cecily:** "I have never met any really wicked person before. I feel rather frightened. I am so afraid he will look just like every one else." Wickedness is treated as glamorous; her fear is that it will not show on the surface. Morality
Q45	**II.44**	**Cecily:** "I hope you have not been leading a double life, pretending to be wicked and being really good all the time. That would be hypocrisy." A precise inversion of the men's double lives, spoken to a man who is leading one, and dramatic irony at its sharpest. Identity · Morality
Q46	**II.60**	**Cecily:** "you would have to choose between this world, the next world, and Australia" A comic tricolon that places a colony in the same list as the afterlife. Religion
Q47	**II.75**	**Algernon:** "Because you are like a pink rose, Cousin Cecily." A conventional compliment, delivered in a garden full of roses; the language of romance is borrowed from stock. Marriage
Q48	**II.81**	**Miss Prism:** "A misanthrope I can understand—a womanthrope, never!" Miss Prism's coinage betrays her hopes of Chasuble beneath the language of moral concern. Gender and inversion · Marriage
Q49	**II.87**	**Miss Prism:** "Young women are green. [Dr. Chasuble starts.] I spoke horticulturally. My metaphor was drawn from fruits." She explains away a sexual implication, echoing Chasuble's own retreat into "metaphor" a few minutes earlier. Gender and inversion · Marriage
Q50	**II.100**	**Miss Prism:** "What a lesson for him! I trust he will profit by it." Death is treated as moral instruction for the dead man himself: piety pushed to absurdity. Religion · Morality
Q51	**II.110**	**Chasuble:** "My sermon on the meaning of the manna in the wilderness can be adapted to almost any occasion, joyful, or, as in the present case, distressing." The all-purpose sermon satirises a clergy that recycles religious language without regard to meaning. Religion

Q52 II.128

Miss Prism: "This seems to me a blessing of an extremely obvious kind."

Turning the platitude about "blessings in disguise", she openly welcomes the death of a sinner.

Religion · Morality

Q53 II.172

Algernon: "My duty as a gentleman has never interfered with my pleasures in the smallest degree."

Duty, Jack's weapon, is brushed aside. Algernon is honest about his selfishness, which is its own kind of earnestness.

Morality · Class

Q54 II.176

Algernon: "It is perfectly childish to be in deep mourning for a man who is actually staying for a whole week with you in your house as a guest."

Algernon describes the absurdity of the situation with complete accuracy, since he is the dead man.

Religion · Identity

Q55 II.199

Cecily: "it is simply a very young girl's record of her own thoughts and impressions, and consequently meant for publication"

"Consequently" makes private writing public; Cecily's diary is a performance with an imagined readership.

Fiction

Q56 II.203

Cecily: "Hopelessly doesn't seem to make much sense, does it?"

Taking his declaration down as dictation, Cecily edits it; she is the author and he supplies the copy.

Marriage · Fiction

Q57 II.210

Cecily: "You silly boy! Of course. Why, we have been engaged for the last three months."

The proposal arrives after the engagement; Cecily's imagination has run ahead of events.

Marriage · Fiction

Q58 II.220

Cecily: "I remember only too well that I was forced to write your letters for you."

She has written both sides of the romance. "Forced" makes her invention sound like a burden imposed by him.

Fiction · Marriage

Q59 II.226

Cecily: "It would hardly have been a really serious engagement if it hadn't been broken off at least once."

Seriousness is measured by drama; she has followed the conventions of romantic fiction in her own life.

Marriage

Q60 II.234

Cecily: "I pity any poor married woman whose husband is not called Ernest."

An exact echo of Gwendolen in Act I. The two heroines share the same obsession, which prepares the comedy of their meeting.

Identity · Marriage

Q61 II.242

Cecily: "He has never written a single book, so you can imagine how much he knows."

An inversion of the usual link between writing and learning.

Fiction

Q62	II.267	**Gwendolen:** "The home seems to me to be the proper sphere for the man. And certainly once a man begins to neglect his domestic duties he becomes painfully effeminate, does he not? And I don't like that. It makes men so very attractive." The Victorian idea of "separate spheres" is applied to men; the final sentence undercuts her own disapproval. Gender and inversion
Q63	II.279	**Gwendolen:** "I wish that you were fully forty-two, and more than usually plain for your age." Rivalry framed as candour; the exact age makes the insult comic. Gender and inversion
Q64	II.296	**Cecily:** "When I see a spade I call it a spade." A plain proverb, which Gwendolen turns into a class insult. Class
Q65	II.297	**Gwendolen:** "I am glad to say that I have never seen a spade. It is obvious that our social spheres have been widely different." Gwendolen takes the idiom literally to imply that Cecily mixes with manual labourers. Class
Q66	II.306	**Gwendolen:** "I had no idea there were any flowers in the country." Town snobbery; Cecily's reply ("as common here . . . as people are in London") wins the exchange. Class
Q67	II.310	**Gwendolen:** "Detestable girl! But I require tea!" An aside reveals the hostility beneath the politeness; appetite outlasts pride. Gender and inversion Class
Q68	II.312	**Gwendolen:** "Sugar is not fashionable any more." Taste is dictated by fashion; Cecily's four lumps of sugar turn etiquette into a weapon. Class
Q69	II.346	**Gwendolen:** "You will call me sister, will you not?" The rivals unite against the men; the line fulfils Jack's prediction in Act I. Gender and inversion
Q70	II.349	**Jack:** "it is very painful for me to be forced to speak the truth. It is the first time in my life that I have ever been reduced to such a painful position" Truth-telling is described as a humiliation; Jack speaks of honesty as though it were a vice. Morality
Q71	II.363	**Algernon:** "Well, one must be serious about something, if one wants to have any amusement in life. I happen to be serious about Bunburying." Seriousness is reserved for pleasure. Algernon accuses Jack of having "an absolutely trivial nature" for being serious about everything else. Morality

Q72	II.375	**Algernon:** "One should always eat muffins quite calmly. It is the only way to eat them." A rule of etiquette offered in a crisis; calm manners over real feeling. Morality
Q73	II.391	**Algernon:** "Science is always making wonderful improvements in things." A satirical swipe at faith in progress, used to justify a convenient change of story. Morality

Act III

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q74	III.2	**Cecily:** "They have been eating muffins. That looks like repentance." An external sign is read as an inner state, the very error the play keeps making comic. Morality
Q75	III.18	**Cecily:** "I don't. But that does not affect the wonderful beauty of his answer." Cecily values the beauty of a statement over its truth. Morality Fiction
Q76	III.19	**Gwendolen:** "In matters of grave importance, style, not sincerity is the vital thing." The play's central paradox in a single line; "grave importance" and "vital" prepare for the title line at the end. Morality
Q77	III.29	**Gwendolen and Cecily:** "Your Christian names are still an insuperable barrier. That is all!" The women speak in unison, a choral joke; "That is all!" reduces the barrier to a name, which is all that matters. Identity
Q78	III.35	**Gwendolen:** "How absurd to talk of the equality of the sexes! Where questions of self-sacrifice are concerned, men are infinitely beyond us." The men's "sacrifice" is a christening; the women's praise mocks the language of heroism. Gender and inversion
Q79	III.44	**Lady Bracknell:** "Hesitation of any kind is a sign of mental decay in the young, of physical weakness in the old." A symmetrical epigram, used as a command. Gender and inversion
Q80	III.44	**Lady Bracknell:** "Indeed I have never undeceived him on any question. I would consider it wrong." Deception within her own marriage is described as a duty, a striking admission from the guardian of propriety. Marriage Morality

Q81	III.56	**Lady Bracknell:** "I am glad, however, that he made up his mind at the last to some definite course of action, and acted under proper medical advice." Death as obedient decision-making, completing her Act I complaint about Bunbury's "shilly-shallying". Religion
Q82	III.61	**Lady Bracknell:** "Until yesterday I had no idea that there were any families or persons whose origin was a Terminus." A railway pun on origin and terminus, recalling Jack's station birth. Identity Class
Q83	III.63	**Lady Bracknell:** "Three addresses always inspire confidence, even in tradesmen." Respectability is measured by property; "even in tradesmen" shows contempt for those who earn money by trade. Class
Q84	III.71	**Lady Bracknell:** "A hundred and thirty thousand pounds! And in the Funds! Miss Cardew seems to me a most attractive young lady, now that I look at her." The stage direction "Sitting down again" and the exclamations show money transforming her view instantly; "now that I look at her" admits she had not looked before. Class Marriage
Q85	III.71	**Lady Bracknell:** "We live, I regret to say, in an age of surfaces." Lady Bracknell condemns superficiality immediately after a judgement based entirely on money and looks. Morality Class
Q86	III.73	**Lady Bracknell:** "There are distinct social possibilities in your profile." Cecily is inspected like a purchase, turned round to be viewed from the side. Class
Q87	III.77	**Lady Bracknell:** "Never speak disrespectfully of Society, Algernon. Only people who can't get into it do that." An epigram that defends Society by insulting its critics as outsiders. Class
Q88	III.77	**Lady Bracknell:** "But I do not approve of mercenary marriages. When I married Lord Bracknell I had no fortune of any kind. But I never dreamed for a moment of allowing that to stand in my way." Her denial of mercenary motives reveals her own: she married up and is now guarding the gate. Marriage Class
Q89	III.86	**Lady Bracknell:** "They give people the opportunity of finding out each other's character before marriage, which I think is never advisable." Ignorance is again preferred to knowledge, now applied to marriage. Marriage

Q90	III.88	**Lady Bracknell:** "He has nothing, but he looks everything. What more can one desire?" Appearance outweighs substance, said with complete sincerity. Class · Morality
Q91	III.90	**Lady Bracknell:** "Untruthful! My nephew Algernon? Impossible! He is an Oxonian." Social credentials are treated as proof of character, though the audience has watched Algernon lie all afternoon. Class · Morality
Q92	III.96	**Lady Bracknell:** "Indeed, no woman should ever be quite accurate about her age. It looks so calculating" Deceit is recommended because honesty looks "calculating", another reversal of the moral vocabulary. Gender and inversion
Q93	III.107	**Jack:** "Then a passionate celibacy is all that any of us can look forward to." An oxymoron that marks the deadlock in the plot. Marriage
Q94	III.126	**Lady Bracknell:** "Prism! Where is that baby?" The repeated, blunt question breaks into the scene and launches the recognition. Identity
Q95	III.126	**Lady Bracknell:** "It contained the manuscript of a three-volume novel of more than usually revolting sentimentality." The lost manuscript of Act II is identified. Lady Bracknell's literary judgement makes the scandal comic. Fiction
Q96	III.127	**Miss Prism:** "In a moment of mental abstraction, for which I never can forgive myself, I deposited the manuscript in the basinette, and placed the baby in the hand-bag." Fiction and life are literally swapped: the novel is cared for like a child while the child is packed like a manuscript. Fiction · Identity
Q97	III.137	**Lady Bracknell:** "I need hardly tell you that in families of high position strange coincidences are not supposed to occur. They are hardly considered the thing." A joke at the expense of the play's own coincidence-driven plot. Class · Fiction
Q98	III.140	**Lady Bracknell:** "I dislike arguments of any kind. They are always vulgar, and often convincing." Being persuaded is a social embarrassment; reason ranks below manners. Class
Q99	III.143	**Gwendolen:** "This suspense is terrible. I hope it will last." Gwendolen enjoys life as a melodrama, in the spirit of her diary-reading on trains. Fiction

Q100 III.150

Jack: "Unmarried! I do not deny that is a serious blow. But after all, who has the right to cast a stone against one who has suffered? Cannot repentance wipe out an act of folly? Why should there be one law for men, and another for women? Mother, I forgive you."

Jack adopts the language of melodrama and scripture ("cast a stone") to forgive a sin no one has committed; the double standard is named, but in absurd circumstances.

Gender and inversion · Religion

Q101 III.152

Jack: "Lady Bracknell, I hate to seem inquisitive, but would you kindly inform me who I am?"

The deepest question of identity is asked as a polite social request.

Identity

Q102 III.161

Lady Bracknell: "Every luxury that money could buy, including christening, had been lavished on you by your fond and doting parents."

A sacrament is listed among luxuries; religion is a purchase.

Religion · Class

Q103 III.158

Gwendolen: "I never change, except in my affections."

Constancy and changeability in one sentence: her principles are fixed, her feelings are not.

Marriage

Q104 III.173

Jack: "it is a terrible thing for a man to find out suddenly that all his life he has been speaking nothing but the truth"

The final inversion: truth is discovered by accident and apologised for.

Morality · Identity

Q105 III.174

Gwendolen: "I can. For I feel that you are sure to change."

Forgiveness given in the expectation of future lies; the marriage begins on the play's own terms.

Marriage

Q106 III.180

Lady Bracknell: "My nephew, you seem to be displaying signs of triviality."

Lady Bracknell calls the embraces "triviality", the word in the play's subtitle.

Morality

Q107 III.181

Jack: "On the contrary, Aunt Augusta, I've now realised for the first time in my life the vital Importance of Being Earnest."

The title line works on two levels: he is Ernest by name, and the pun mocks the Victorian ideal of earnestness, since he has achieved it by luck rather than by sincerity.

Identity · Morality

Past questions

From the past-paper collection supplied with this guide (IGCSE 0486, 2013). Each extract is mapped to the play by line number so you can find it in any edition.

The twelve passage-based extracts in the supplied collection fall across the play as follows: Act I, 5; Act II, 4; Act III, 3. Moments not yet set as extracts in this collection include Jack's entrance in mourning II.88–128, Lady Bracknell's examination of Cecily III.57–86 and the recognition scene with Miss Prism III.125–133. That is a pattern in twelve papers, not a forecast.

Approaching the passage-based question

Read the question's key words first ("comic", "ridicule", "engages the interest") and keep them in every paragraph. Place the extract in the play in a sentence: what has just happened and what the audience knows that the characters do not. Work through the passage in order, quoting short phrases and stage directions, and say what an audience would see and hear. Refer briefly to other parts of the play only where they sharpen the point.

Approaching the essay question

Choose three or four moments from different acts, so the answer shows the arc. The event bank and theme arcs give ready-made sequences. With an open text you can find exact quotations, so the marks go to what you do with them: link each to the question and to Wilde's methods.

P1 Act I I.1–38 0486/12/O/N/13

Passage: from "Did you hear what I was playing, Lane?" to "How utterly unromantic you are!"

> **Algernon:** Did you hear what I was playing, Lane?
>
> **Lane:** I didn't think it polite to listen, sir.
>
> **Algernon:** I'm sorry for that, for your sake. I don't play accurately—any one can play accurately—but I play with wonderful expression. As far as the piano is concerned, sentiment is my forte. I keep science for Life.
>
> **Lane:** Yes, sir.
>
> **Algernon:** And, speaking of the science of Life, have you got the cucumber sandwiches cut for Lady Bracknell?
>
> **Lane:** Yes, sir. [Hands them on a salver.]
>
> **Algernon:** [Inspects them, takes two, and sits down on the sofa.] Oh! . . . by the way, Lane, I see from your book that on Thursday night, when Lord Shoreman and Mr. Worthing were dining with me, eight bottles of champagne are entered as having been consumed.
>
> **Lane:** Yes, sir; eight bottles and a pint.
>
> **Algernon:** Why is it that at a bachelor's establishment the servants invariably drink the champagne? I ask merely for information.
>
> **Lane:** I attribute it to the superior quality of the wine, sir. I have often observed that in married households the champagne is rarely of a first-rate brand.
>
> **Algernon:** Good heavens! Is marriage so demoralising as that?
>
> **Lane:** I believe it is a very pleasant state, sir. I have had very little experience of it myself up to the present. I have only been married once. That was in consequence of a misunderstanding between myself and a young person.
>
> **Algernon:** [Languidly.] I don't know that I am much interested in your family life, Lane.
>
> **Lane:** No, sir; it is not a very interesting subject. I never think of it myself.

> **Algernon:** Very natural, I am sure. That will do, Lane, thank you.
>
> **Lane:** Thank you, sir. [Lane goes out.]
>
> **Algernon:** Lane's views on marriage seem somewhat lax. Really, if the lower orders don't set us a good example, what on earth is the use of them? They seem, as a class, to have absolutely no sense of moral responsibility.
>
> *[Enter Lane.]*
>
> **Lane:** Mr. Ernest Worthing.
>
> *[Enter Jack.]*
>
> *[Lane goes out.]*
>
> **Algernon:** How are you, my dear Ernest? What brings you up to town?
>
> **Jack:** Oh, pleasure, pleasure! What else should bring one anywhere? Eating as usual, I see, Algy!
>
> **Algernon:** [Stiffly.] I believe it is customary in good society to take some slight refreshment at five o'clock. Where have you been since last Thursday?
>
> **Jack:** [Sitting down on the sofa.] In the country.
>
> **Algernon:** What on earth do you do there?
>
> **Jack:** [Pulling off his gloves.] When one is in town one amuses oneself. When one is in the country one amuses other people. It is excessively boring.
>
> **Algernon:** And who are the people you amuse?
>
> **Jack:** [Airily.] Oh, neighbours, neighbours.
>
> **Algernon:** Got nice neighbours in your part of Shropshire?
>
> **Jack:** Perfectly horrid! Never speak to one of them.
>
> **Algernon:** How immensely you must amuse them! [Goes over and takes sandwich.] By the way, Shropshire is your county, is it not?
>
> **Jack:** Eh? Shropshire? Yes, of course. Hallo! Why all these cups? Why cucumber sandwiches? Why such reckless extravagance in one so young? Who is coming to tea?
>
> **Algernon:** Oh! merely Aunt Augusta and Gwendolen.
>
> **Jack:** How perfectly delightful!
>
> **Algernon:** Yes, that is all very well; but I am afraid Aunt Augusta won't quite approve of your being here.
>
> **Jack:** May I ask why?
>
> **Algernon:** My dear fellow, the way you flirt with Gwendolen is perfectly disgraceful. It is almost as bad as the way Gwendolen flirts with you.
>
> **Jack:** I am in love with Gwendolen. I have come up to town expressly to propose to her.
>
> **Algernon:** I thought you had come up for pleasure? . . . I call that business.
>
> **Jack:** How utterly unromantic you are!

Passage-based: How does Wilde make this such a humorously effective opening to the play?

Alternative: How does Wilde make Miss Prism's attempts to 'improve' Cecily so funny? Support your ideas with details from Wilde's writing.

Look for. Master–servant inversion; Lane's deadpan register; first introduction of "Ernest"; town/country epigram; the cucumber sandwiches as a running visual joke.

P2 Act I I.58–78

Passage: from "I think that is rather mean of you, Ernest, I must say. [Opens case and examines it.] Howe…" to "… it is. [Hands cigarette case.] Now produce your explanation, and pray make it improbable."

> **Algernon:** I think that is rather mean of you, Ernest, I must say. [Opens case and examines it.] However, it makes no matter, for, now that I look at the inscription inside, I find that the thing isn't yours after all.

Jack: Of course it's mine. [Moving to him.] You have seen me with it a hundred times, and you have no right whatsoever to read what is written inside. It is a very ungentlemanly thing to read a private cigarette case.

Algernon: Oh! it is absurd to have a hard and fast rule about what one should read and what one shouldn't. More than half of modern culture depends on what one shouldn't read.

Jack: I am quite aware of the fact, and I don't propose to discuss modern culture. It isn't the sort of thing one should talk of in private. I simply want my cigarette case back.

Algernon: Yes; but this isn't your cigarette case. This cigarette case is a present from some one of the name of Cecily, and you said you didn't know any one of that name.

Jack: Well, if you want to know, Cecily happens to be my aunt.

Algernon: Your aunt!

Jack: Yes. Charming old lady she is, too. Lives at Tunbridge Wells. Just give it back to me, Algy.

Algernon: [Retreating to back of sofa.] But why does she call herself little Cecily if she is your aunt and lives at Tunbridge Wells? [Reading.] 'From little Cecily with her fondest love.'

Jack: [Moving to sofa and kneeling upon it.] My dear fellow, what on earth is there in that? Some aunts are tall, some aunts are not tall. That is a matter that surely an aunt may be allowed to decide for herself. You seem to think that every aunt should be exactly like your aunt! That is absurd! For Heaven's sake give me back my cigarette case. [Follows Algernon round the room.]

Algernon: Yes. But why does your aunt call you her uncle? 'From little Cecily, with her fondest love to her dear Uncle Jack.' There is no objection, I admit, to an aunt being a small aunt, but why an aunt, no matter what her size may be, should call her own nephew her uncle, I can't quite make out. Besides, your name isn't Jack at all; it is Ernest.

Jack: It isn't Ernest; it's Jack.

Algernon: You have always told me it was Ernest. I have introduced you to every one as Ernest. You answer to the name of Ernest. You look as if your name was Ernest. You are the most earnest-looking person I ever saw in my life. It is perfectly absurd your saying that your name isn't Ernest. It's on your cards. Here is one of them. [Taking it from case.] 'Mr. Ernest Worthing, B. 4, The Albany.' I'll keep this as a proof that your name is Ernest if ever you attempt to deny it to me, or to Gwendolen, or to any one else. [Puts the card in his pocket.]

Jack: Well, my name is Ernest in town and Jack in the country, and the cigarette case was given to me in the country.

Algernon: Yes, but that does not account for the fact that your small Aunt Cecily, who lives at Tunbridge Wells, calls you her dear uncle. Come, old boy, you had much better have the thing out at once.

Jack: My dear Algy, you talk exactly as if you were a dentist. It is very vulgar to talk like a dentist when one isn't a dentist. It produces a false impression.

Algernon: Well, that is exactly what dentists always do. Now, go on! Tell me the whole thing. I may mention that I have always suspected you of being a confirmed and secret Bunburyist; and I am quite sure of it now.

Jack: Bunburyist? What on earth do you mean by a Bunburyist?

Algernon: I'll reveal to you the meaning of that incomparable expression as soon as you are kind enough to inform me why you are Ernest in town and Jack in the country.

Jack: Well, produce my cigarette case first.

Algernon: Here it is. [Hands cigarette case.] Now produce your explanation, and pray make it improbable.

Passage-based: Explore how Wilde engages the interest of the audience in this early moment in the play.

Alternative: How far does Wilde's portrayal of Gwendolen suggest that Jack Worthing is a lucky man to be marrying her? Support your views with details from Wilde's writing.

Look for. The cigarette case as evidence; the aunt joke; chasing round the sofa (stage directions); first use of "Bunburyist"; the pun on Ernest/earnest; suspense deferred.

P3 Act I I.176–203

Passage: from "You can take a seat, Mr. Worthing." to "I am afraid I really don't know."

Lady Bracknell: You can take a seat, Mr. Worthing.

[Looks in her pocket for note-book and pencil.]

Jack: Thank you, Lady Bracknell, I prefer standing.

Lady Bracknell: [Pencil and note-book in hand.] I feel bound to tell you that you are not down on my list of eligible young men, although I have the same list as the dear Duchess of Bolton has. We work together, in fact. However, I am quite ready to enter your name, should your answers be what a really affectionate mother requires. Do you smoke?

Jack: Well, yes, I must admit I smoke.

Lady Bracknell: I am glad to hear it. A man should always have an occupation of some kind. There are far too many idle men in London as it is. How old are you?

Jack: Twenty-nine.

Lady Bracknell: A very good age to be married at. I have always been of opinion that a man who desires to get married should know either everything or nothing. Which do you know?

Jack: [After some hesitation.] I know nothing, Lady Bracknell.

Lady Bracknell: I am pleased to hear it. I do not approve of anything that tampers with natural ignorance. Ignorance is like a delicate exotic fruit; touch it and the bloom is gone. The whole theory of modern education is radically unsound. Fortunately in England, at any rate, education produces no effect whatsoever. If it did, it would prove a serious danger to the upper classes, and probably lead to acts of violence in Grosvenor Square. What is your income?

Jack: Between seven and eight thousand a year.

Lady Bracknell: [Makes a note in her book.] In land, or in investments?

Jack: In investments, chiefly.

Lady Bracknell: That is satisfactory. What between the duties expected of one during one's lifetime, and the duties exacted from one after one's death, land has ceased to be either a profit or a pleasure. It gives one position, and prevents one from keeping it up. That's all that can be said about land.

Jack: I have a country house with some land, of course, attached to it, about fifteen hundred acres, I believe; but I don't depend on that for my real income. In fact, as far as I can make out, the poachers are the only people who make anything out of it.

Lady Bracknell: A country house! How many bedrooms? Well, that point can be cleared up afterwards. You have a town house, I hope? A girl with a simple, unspoiled nature, like Gwendolen, could hardly be expected to reside in the country.

Jack: Well, I own a house in Belgrave Square, but it is let by the year to Lady Bloxham. Of course, I can get it back whenever I like, at six months' notice.

Lady Bracknell: Lady Bloxham? I don't know her.

Jack: Oh, she goes about very little. She is a lady considerably advanced in years.

Lady Bracknell: Ah, nowadays that is no guarantee of respectability of character. What number in Belgrave Square?

Jack: 149.

Lady Bracknell: [Shaking her head.] The unfashionable side. I thought there was something. However, that could easily be altered.

Jack: Do you mean the fashion, or the side?

Lady Bracknell: [Sternly.] Both, if necessary, I presume. What are your politics?

Jack: Well, I am afraid I really have none. I am a Liberal Unionist.

Lady Bracknell: Oh, they count as Tories. They dine with us. Or come in the evening, at any rate. Now to minor matters. Are your parents living?

Jack: I have lost both my parents.

Lady Bracknell: To lose one parent, Mr. Worthing, may be regarded as a misfortune; to lose both looks like carelessness. Who was your father? He was evidently a man of some wealth. Was he born in what the Radical papers call the purple of commerce, or did he rise from the ranks of the aristocracy?

Jack: I am afraid I really don't know.

Passage-based: How does Wilde at this moment in the play ridicule the ways in which the upper class arranges the marriages of its daughters? Support your ideas with details from the writing.

Alternative: Explore two moments in the play in which Wilde makes the audience laugh at the absurd ways in which people can behave. (Do not use the extract in Question 10.)

Look for. The notebook and the list; questions in absurd order of priority; epigrams on ignorance, land and politics; Jack standing while she sits.

P4 Act I I.201–217 0486/12/M/J/13

Passage: from "I have lost both my parents." to "Well, I don't see how I could possibly manage to do that."

> **Jack:** I have lost both my parents.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** To lose one parent, Mr. Worthing, may be regarded as a misfortune; to lose both looks like carelessness. Who was your father? He was evidently a man of some wealth. Was he born in what the Radical papers call the purple of commerce, or did he rise from the ranks of the aristocracy?
>
> **Jack:** I am afraid I really don't know. The fact is, Lady Bracknell, I said I had lost my parents. It would be nearer the truth to say that my parents seem to have lost me . . . I don't actually know who I am by birth. I was . . . well, I was found.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** Found!
>
> **Jack:** The late Mr. Thomas Cardew, an old gentleman of a very charitable and kindly disposition, found me, and gave me the name of Worthing, because he happened to have a first-class ticket for Worthing in his pocket at the time. Worthing is a place in Sussex. It is a seaside resort.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** Where did the charitable gentleman who had a first-class ticket for this seaside resort find you?
>
> **Jack:** [Gravely.] In a hand-bag.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** A hand-bag?
>
> **Jack:** [Very seriously.] Yes, Lady Bracknell. I was in a hand-bag—a somewhat large, black leather hand-bag, with handles to it—an ordinary hand-bag in fact.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** In what locality did this Mr. James, or Thomas, Cardew come across this ordinary hand-bag?
>
> **Jack:** In the cloak-room at Victoria Station. It was given to him in mistake for his own.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** The cloak-room at Victoria Station?
>
> **Jack:** Yes. The Brighton line.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** The line is immaterial. Mr. Worthing, I confess I feel somewhat bewildered by what you have just told me. To be born, or at any rate bred, in a hand-bag, whether it had handles or not, seems to me to display a contempt for the ordinary decencies of family life that reminds one of the worst excesses of the French Revolution. And I presume you know what that unfortunate movement led to? As for the particular locality in which the hand-bag was found, a cloak-room at a railway station might serve to conceal a social indiscretion—has probably, indeed, been used for that purpose before now—but it could hardly be regarded as an assured basis for a recognised position in good society.
>
> **Jack:** May I ask you then what you would advise me to do? I need hardly say I would do anything in the world to ensure Gwendolen's happiness.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** I would strongly advise you, Mr. Worthing, to try and acquire some relations as soon as possible, and to make a definite effort to produce at any rate one parent, of either sex, before the season is quite over.
>
> **Jack:** Well, I don't see how I could possibly manage to do that.

Passage-based: What do you think makes this such a memorably comic moment in the play? Support your ideas with details from Wilde's writing.

Alternative: Explore two moments in the play in which Wilde surprises the audience. (Do not use the passage printed in Question 10.)

Look for. "Carelessness" epigram; Jack's grave and very serious delivery; repetition of "hand-bag"; the French Revolution hyperbole; advice to "acquire some relations".

P5 Act I I.270–301 0486/11/O/N/13

Passage: from "My own darling!" to "…t him, and leaves the room. Algernon lights a cigarette, reads his shirt-cuff, and smiles."

> **Jack:** My own darling!
>
> **Gwendolen:** Ernest, we may never be married. From the expression on mamma's face I fear we never shall. Few parents nowadays pay any regard to what their children say to them. The old-fashioned respect for the young is fast dying out. Whatever influence I ever had over mamma, I lost at the age of three. But although she may prevent us from becoming man and wife, and I may marry some one else, and marry often, nothing that she can possibly do can alter my eternal devotion to you.
>
> **Jack:** Dear Gwendolen!
>
> **Gwendolen:** The story of your romantic origin, as related to me by mamma, with unpleasing comments, has naturally stirred the deeper fibres of my nature. Your Christian name has an irresistible fascination. The simplicity of your character makes you exquisitely incomprehensible to me. Your town address at the Albany I have. What is your address in the country?
>
> **Jack:** The Manor House, Woolton, Hertfordshire.
>
> *[Algernon, who has been carefully listening, smiles to himself, and writes the address on his shirt-cuff. Then picks up the Railway Guide.]*
>
> **Gwendolen:** There is a good postal service, I suppose? It may be necessary to do something desperate. That of course will require serious consideration. I will communicate with you daily.
>
> **Jack:** My own one!
>
> **Gwendolen:** How long do you remain in town?
>
> **Jack:** Till Monday.
>
> **Gwendolen:** Good! Algy, you may turn round now.
>
> **Algernon:** Thanks, I've turned round already.
>
> **Gwendolen:** You may also ring the bell.
>
> **Jack:** You will let me see you to your carriage, my own darling?
>
> **Gwendolen:** Certainly.
>
> **Jack:** [To Lane, who now enters.] I will see Miss Fairfax out.
>
> **Lane:** Yes, sir. [Jack and Gwendolen go off.]
>
> *[Lane presents several letters on a salver to Algernon. It is to be surmised that they are bills, as Algernon, after looking at the envelopes, tears them up.]*
>
> **Algernon:** A glass of sherry, Lane.
>
> **Lane:** Yes, sir.
>
> **Algernon:** To-morrow, Lane, I'm going Bunburying.
>
> **Lane:** Yes, sir.
>
> **Algernon:** I shall probably not be back till Monday. You can put up my dress clothes, my smoking jacket, and all the Bunbury suits . . .
>
> **Lane:** Yes, sir. [Handing sherry.]
>
> **Algernon:** I hope to-morrow will be a fine day, Lane.
>
> **Lane:** It never is, sir.
>
> **Algernon:** Lane, you're a perfect pessimist.
>
> **Lane:** I do my best to give satisfaction, sir.
>
> *[Enter Jack. Lane goes off.]*
>
> **Jack:** There's a sensible, intellectual girl! the only girl I ever cared for in my life. [Algernon is laughing immoderately.] What on earth are you so amused at?

> **Algernon:** Oh, I'm a little anxious about poor Bunbury, that is all.
>
> **Jack:** If you don't take care, your friend Bunbury will get you into a serious scrape some day.
>
> **Algernon:** I love scrapes. They are the only things that are never serious.
>
> **Jack:** Oh, that's nonsense, Algy. You never talk anything but nonsense.
>
> **Algernon:** Nobody ever does.
>
> *[Jack looks indignantly at him, and leaves the room. Algernon lights a cigarette, reads his shirt-cuff, and smiles.*

Passage-based: How does Wilde make the audience at the end of Act 1 wonder what may happen next?

Alternative: How does Wilde make Lady Bracknell such a memorably amusing character? Support your ideas with details from the play.

Look for. The shirt-cuff and Railway Guide (stage directions); bills torn up; "To-morrow… Bunburying"; dramatic irony as Jack fails to see Algernon laughing; the closing visual.

P6 Act II II.10–34

Passage: from "I keep a diary in order to enter the wonderful secrets of my life. If I didn't write them …" to "…ws them back on table.] Horrid Political Economy! Horrid Geography! Horrid, horrid German!"

> **Cecily:** I keep a diary in order to enter the wonderful secrets of my life. If I didn't write them down, I should probably forget all about them.
>
> **Miss Prism:** Memory, my dear Cecily, is the diary that we all carry about with us.
>
> **Cecily:** Yes, but it usually chronicles the things that have never happened, and couldn't possibly have happened. I believe that Memory is responsible for nearly all the three-volume novels that Mudie sends us.
>
> **Miss Prism:** Do not speak slightingly of the three-volume novel, Cecily. I wrote one myself in earlier days.
>
> **Cecily:** Did you really, Miss Prism? How wonderfully clever you are! I hope it did not end happily? I don't like novels that end happily. They depress me so much.
>
> **Miss Prism:** The good ended happily, and the bad unhappily. That is what Fiction means.
>
> **Cecily:** I suppose so. But it seems very unfair. And was your novel ever published?
>
> **Miss Prism:** Alas! no. The manuscript unfortunately was abandoned. [Cecily starts.] I use the word in the sense of lost or mislaid. To your work, child, these speculations are profitless.
>
> **Cecily:** [Smiling.] But I see dear Dr. Chasuble coming up through the garden.
>
> **Miss Prism:** [Rising and advancing.] Dr. Chasuble! This is indeed a pleasure.
>
> *[Enter Canon Chasuble.]*
>
> **Chasuble:** And how are we this morning? Miss Prism, you are, I trust, well?
>
> **Cecily:** Miss Prism has just been complaining of a slight headache. I think it would do her so much good to have a short stroll with you in the Park, Dr. Chasuble.
>
> **Miss Prism:** Cecily, I have not mentioned anything about a headache.
>
> **Cecily:** No, dear Miss Prism, I know that, but I felt instinctively that you had a headache. Indeed I was thinking about that, and not about my German lesson, when the Rector came in.
>
> **Chasuble:** I hope, Cecily, you are not inattentive.
>
> **Cecily:** Oh, I am afraid I am.
>
> **Chasuble:** That is strange. Were I fortunate enough to be Miss Prism's pupil, I would hang upon her lips. [Miss Prism glares.] I spoke metaphorically.—My metaphor was drawn from bees. Ahem! Mr. Worthing, I suppose, has not returned from town yet?
>
> **Miss Prism:** We do not expect him till Monday afternoon.

Chasuble: Ah yes, he usually likes to spend his Sunday in London. He is not one of those whose sole aim is enjoyment, as, by all accounts, that unfortunate young man his brother seems to be. But I must not disturb Egeria and her pupil any longer.

Miss Prism: Egeria? My name is Lætitia, Doctor.

Chasuble: [Bowing.] A classical allusion merely, drawn from the Pagan authors. I shall see you both no doubt at Evensong?

Miss Prism: I think, dear Doctor, I will have a stroll with you. I find I have a headache after all, and a walk might do it good.

Chasuble: With pleasure, Miss Prism, with pleasure. We might go as far as the schools and back.

Miss Prism: That would be delightful. Cecily, you will read your Political Economy in my absence. The chapter on the Fall of the Rupee you may omit. It is somewhat too sensational. Even these metallic problems have their melodramatic side.

[Goes down the garden with Dr. Chasuble.]

Cecily: [Picks up books and throws them back on table.] Horrid Political Economy! Horrid Geography! Horrid, horrid German!

Passage-based: How does Wilde amusingly reveal the thoughts of the characters here?

Alternative: Explore in detail two moments in the play which Wilde makes particularly amusing for you. (Do not use the extract printed in Question 10.)

Look for. Cecily's invented headache; Chasuble and Prism's metaphors; the "abandoned" manuscript; Cecily's outburst at the end.

P7 Act II II.193–227

Passage: from "The dog-cart is at the door, sir. [Algernon looks appealingly at Cecily.]" to "[Crossing to her, and kneeling.] What a perfect angel you are, Cecily."

Merriman: The dog-cart is at the door, sir. [Algernon looks appealingly at Cecily.]

Cecily: It can wait, Merriman for . . . five minutes.

Merriman: Yes, Miss. [Exit Merriman.]

Algernon: I hope, Cecily, I shall not offend you if I state quite frankly and openly that you seem to me to be in every way the visible personification of absolute perfection.

Cecily: I think your frankness does you great credit, Ernest. If you will allow me, I will copy your remarks into my diary. [Goes over to table and begins writing in diary.]

Algernon: Do you really keep a diary? I'd give anything to look at it. May I?

Cecily: Oh no. [Puts her hand over it.] You see, it is simply a very young girl's record of her own thoughts and impressions, and consequently meant for publication. When it appears in volume form I hope you will order a copy. But pray, Ernest, don't stop. I delight in taking down from dictation. I have reached 'absolute perfection'. You can go on. I am quite ready for more.

Algernon: [Somewhat taken aback.] Ahem! Ahem!

Cecily: Oh, don't cough, Ernest. When one is dictating one should speak fluently and not cough. Besides, I don't know how to spell a cough. [Writes as Algernon speaks.]

Algernon: [Speaking very rapidly.] Cecily, ever since I first looked upon your wonderful and incomparable beauty, I have dared to love you wildly, passionately, devotedly, hopelessly.

Cecily: I don't think that you should tell me that you love me wildly, passionately, devotedly, hopelessly. Hopelessly doesn't seem to make much sense, does it?

Algernon: Cecily!

[Enter Merriman.]

Merriman: The dog-cart is waiting, sir.

Algernon: Tell it to come round next week, at the same hour.

Merriman: [Looks at Cecily, who makes no sign.] Yes, sir.

[Merriman retires.]

Cecily: Uncle Jack would be very much annoyed if he knew you were staying on till next week, at the same hour.

Algernon: Oh, I don't care about Jack. I don't care for anybody in the whole world but you. I love you, Cecily. You will marry me, won't you?

Cecily: You silly boy! Of course. Why, we have been engaged for the last three months.

Algernon: For the last three months?

Cecily: Yes, it will be exactly three months on Thursday.

Algernon: But how did we become engaged?

Cecily: Well, ever since dear Uncle Jack first confessed to us that he had a younger brother who was very wicked and bad, you of course have formed the chief topic of conversation between myself and Miss Prism. And of course a man who is much talked about is always very attractive. One feels there must be something in him, after all. I daresay it was foolish of me, but I fell in love with you, Ernest.

Algernon: Darling! And when was the engagement actually settled?

Cecily: On the 14th of February last. Worn out by your entire ignorance of my existence, I determined to end the matter one way or the other, and after a long struggle with myself I accepted you under this dear old tree here. The next day I bought this little ring in your name, and this is the little bangle with the true lover's knot I promised you always to wear.

Algernon: Did I give you this? It's very pretty, isn't it?

Cecily: Yes, you've wonderfully good taste, Ernest. It's the excuse I've always given for your leading such a bad life. And this is the box in which I keep all your dear letters. [Kneels at table, opens box, and produces letters tied up with blue ribbon.]

Algernon: My letters! But, my own sweet Cecily, I have never written you any letters.

Cecily: You need hardly remind me of that, Ernest. I remember only too well that I was forced to write your letters for you. I wrote always three times a week, and sometimes oftener.

Algernon: Oh, do let me read them, Cecily?

Cecily: Oh, I couldn't possibly. They would make you far too conceited. [Replaces box.] The three you wrote me after I had broken off the engagement are so beautiful, and so badly spelled, that even now I can hardly read them without crying a little.

Algernon: But was our engagement ever broken off?

Cecily: Of course it was. On the 22nd of last March. You can see the entry if you like. [Shows diary.] 'To-day I broke off my engagement with Ernest. I feel it is better to do so. The weather still continues charming.'

Algernon: But why on earth did you break it off? What had I done? I had done nothing at all. Cecily, I am very much hurt indeed to hear you broke it off. Particularly when the weather was so charming.

Cecily: It would hardly have been a really serious engagement if it hadn't been broken off at least once. But I forgave you before the week was out.

Algernon: [Crossing to her, and kneeling.] What a perfect angel you are, Cecily.

Passage-based: How does Wilde make this proposal of marriage such a hilarious moment in the play?

Alternative: How does Wilde make the way Jack Worthing has to live his life so comically complicated? Support your ideas with details from the writing.

Look for. Dictation; Cecily's editing of "hopelessly"; the engagement that predates the proposal; letters she wrote herself; the diary entry about the weather.

P8 Act II II.309–346

Passage: from "May I offer you some tea, Miss Fairfax?" to "[Slowly and seriously.] You will call me sister, will you not?"

> **Cecily:** May I offer you some tea, Miss Fairfax?
>
> **Gwendolen:** [With elaborate politeness.] Thank you. [Aside.] Detestable girl! But I require tea!
>
> **Cecily:** [Sweetly.] Sugar?
>
> **Gwendolen:** [Superciliously.] No, thank you. Sugar is not fashionable any more. [Cecily looks angrily at her, takes up the tongs and puts four lumps of sugar into the cup.]
>
> **Cecily:** [Severely.] Cake or bread and butter?
>
> **Gwendolen:** [In a bored manner.] Bread and butter, please. Cake is rarely seen at the best houses nowadays.
>
> **Cecily:** [Cuts a very large slice of cake, and puts it on the tray.] Hand that to Miss Fairfax.
>
> *[Merriman does so, and goes out with footman. Gwendolen drinks the tea and makes a grimace. Puts down cup at once, reaches out her hand to the bread and butter, looks at it, and finds it is cake. Rises in indignation.]*
>
> **Gwendolen:** You have filled my tea with lumps of sugar, and though I asked most distinctly for bread and butter, you have given me cake. I am known for the gentleness of my disposition, and the extraordinary sweetness of my nature, but I warn you, Miss Cardew, you may go too far.
>
> **Cecily:** [Rising.] To save my poor, innocent, trusting boy from the machinations of any other girl there are no lengths to which I would not go.
>
> **Gwendolen:** From the moment I saw you I distrusted you. I felt that you were false and deceitful. I am never deceived in such matters. My first impressions of people are invariably right.
>
> **Cecily:** It seems to me, Miss Fairfax, that I am trespassing on your valuable time. No doubt you have many other calls of a similar character to make in the neighbourhood.
>
> *[Enter Jack.]*
>
> **Gwendolen:** [Catching sight of him.] Ernest! My own Ernest!
>
> **Jack:** Gwendolen! Darling! [Offers to kiss her.]
>
> **Gwendolen:** [Draws back.] A moment! May I ask if you are engaged to be married to this young lady? [Points to Cecily.]
>
> **Jack:** [Laughing.] To dear little Cecily! Of course not! What could have put such an idea into your pretty little head?
>
> **Gwendolen:** Thank you. You may! [Offers her cheek.]
>
> **Cecily:** [Very sweetly.] I knew there must be some misunderstanding, Miss Fairfax. The gentleman whose arm is at present round your waist is my guardian, Mr. John Worthing.
>
> **Gwendolen:** I beg your pardon?
>
> **Cecily:** This is Uncle Jack.
>
> **Gwendolen:** [Receding.] Jack! Oh!
>
> *[Enter Algernon.]*
>
> **Cecily:** Here is Ernest.
>
> **Algernon:** [Goes straight over to Cecily without noticing any one else.] My own love! [Offers to kiss her.]
>
> **Cecily:** [Drawing back.] A moment, Ernest! May I ask you—are you engaged to be married to this young lady?
>
> **Algernon:** [Looking round.] To what young lady? Good heavens! Gwendolen!
>
> **Cecily:** Yes! to good heavens, Gwendolen, I mean to Gwendolen.
>
> **Algernon:** [Laughing.] Of course not! What could have put such an idea into your pretty little head?
>
> **Cecily:** Thank you. [Presenting her cheek to be kissed.] You may. [Algernon kisses her.]
>
> **Gwendolen:** I felt there was some slight error, Miss Cardew. The gentleman who is now embracing you is my cousin, Mr. Algernon Moncrieff.
>
> **Cecily:** [Breaking away from Algernon.] Algernon Moncrieff! Oh! [The two girls move towards each other and put their arms round each other's waists as if for protection.]

> **Cecily:** Are you called Algernon?
>
> **Algernon:** I cannot deny it.
>
> **Cecily:** Oh!
>
> **Gwendolen:** Is your name really John?
>
> **Jack:** [Standing rather proudly.] I could deny it if I liked. I could deny anything if I liked. But my name certainly is John. It has been John for years.
>
> **Cecily:** [To Gwendolen.] A gross deception has been practised on both of us.
>
> **Gwendolen:** My poor wounded Cecily!
>
> **Cecily:** My sweet wronged Gwendolen!
>
> **Gwendolen:** [Slowly and seriously.] You will call me sister, will you not?

Passage-based: Explore the ways in which Wilde makes the various misunderstandings and their effects so hilarious at this moment in the play.

Alternative: How do you think Wilde makes Dr. Chasuble such an amusing character in the play? Support your views with details from Wilde's writing.

Look for. Aside; sugar and cake; mirrored entrances and identical lines; the women's embrace "as if for protection"; Jack's proud "It has been John for years".

P9 Act II II.374–397

Passage: from "How can you sit there, calmly eating muffins when we are in this horrible trouble, I can't…" to "…ll one muffin left. [Jack groans, and sinks into a chair. Algernon still continues eating."

> **Jack:** How can you sit there, calmly eating muffins when we are in this horrible trouble, I can't make out. You seem to me to be perfectly heartless.
>
> **Algernon:** Well, I can't eat muffins in an agitated manner. The butter would probably get on my cuffs. One should always eat muffins quite calmly. It is the only way to eat them.
>
> **Jack:** I say it's perfectly heartless your eating muffins at all, under the circumstances.
>
> **Algernon:** When I am in trouble, eating is the only thing that consoles me. Indeed, when I am in really great trouble, as any one who knows me intimately will tell you, I refuse everything except food and drink. At the present moment I am eating muffins because I am unhappy. Besides, I am particularly fond of muffins. [Rising.]
>
> **Jack:** [Rising.] Well, that is no reason why you should eat them all in that greedy way. [Takes muffins from Algernon.]
>
> **Algernon:** [Offering tea-cake.] I wish you would have tea-cake instead. I don't like tea-cake.
>
> **Jack:** Good heavens! I suppose a man may eat his own muffins in his own garden.
>
> **Algernon:** But you have just said it was perfectly heartless to eat muffins.
>
> **Jack:** I said it was perfectly heartless of you, under the circumstances. That is a very different thing.
>
> **Algernon:** That may be. But the muffins are the same. [He seizes the muffin-dish from Jack.]
>
> **Jack:** Algy, I wish to goodness you would go.
>
> **Algernon:** You can't possibly ask me to go without having some dinner. It's absurd. I never go without my dinner. No one ever does, except vegetarians and people like that. Besides I have just made arrangements with Dr. Chasuble to be christened at a quarter to six under the name of Ernest.
>
> **Jack:** My dear fellow, the sooner you give up that nonsense the better. I made arrangements this morning with Dr. Chasuble to be christened myself at 5.30, and I naturally will take the name of Ernest. Gwendolen would wish it. We can't both be christened Ernest. It's absurd. Besides, I have a perfect right to be christened if I like. There is no evidence at all that I have ever been christened by anybody. I should think it extremely probable I never was, and so does Dr. Chasuble. It is entirely different in your case. You have been christened already.
>
> **Algernon:** Yes, but I have not been christened for years.
>
> **Jack:** Yes, but you have been christened. That is the important thing.

Algernon: Quite so. So I know my constitution can stand it. If you are not quite sure about your ever having been christened, I must say I think it rather dangerous your venturing on it now. It might make you very unwell. You can hardly have forgotten that some one very closely connected with you was very nearly carried off this week in Paris by a severe chill.

Jack: Yes, but you said yourself that a severe chill was not hereditary.

Algernon: It usen't to be, I know—but I daresay it is now. Science is always making wonderful improvements in things.

Jack: [Picking up the muffin-dish.] Oh, that is nonsense; you are always talking nonsense.

Algernon: Jack, you are at the muffins again! I wish you wouldn't. There are only two left. [Takes them.] I told you I was particularly fond of muffins.

Jack: But I hate tea-cake.

Algernon: Why on earth then do you allow tea-cake to be served up for your guests? What ideas you have of hospitality!

Jack: Algernon! I have already told you to go. I don't want you here. Why don't you go!

Algernon: I haven't quite finished my tea yet! and there is still one muffin left. [Jack groans, and sinks into a chair. Algernon still continues eating.

Passage-based: How does Wilde make this such an amusing ending to Act 2?

Alternative: Explore the ways in which Wilde makes Cecily such an amusing character. Support your ideas with details from the writing.

Look for. Muffin-dish snatched back and forth; logic of "perfectly heartless of you"; rival christenings; the severe chill callback; Algernon still eating at the curtain.

P10 Act III III.1–41 0486/13/M/J/13

Passage: from "The fact that they did not follow us at once into the house, as any one else would have do…" to "Good heavens!"

Gwendolen: The fact that they did not follow us at once into the house, as any one else would have done, seems to me to show that they have some sense of shame left.

Cecily: They have been eating muffins. That looks like repentance.

Gwendolen: [After a pause.] They don't seem to notice us at all. Couldn't you cough?

Cecily: But I haven't got a cough.

Gwendolen: They're looking at us. What effrontery!

Cecily: They're approaching. That's very forward of them.

Gwendolen: Let us preserve a dignified silence.

Cecily: Certainly. It's the only thing to do now. [Enter Jack followed by Algernon. They whistle some dreadful popular air from a British Opera.]

Gwendolen: This dignified silence seems to produce an unpleasant effect.

Cecily: A most distasteful one.

Gwendolen: But we will not be the first to speak.

Cecily: Certainly not.

Gwendolen: Mr. Worthing, I have something very particular to ask you. Much depends on your reply.

Cecily: Gwendolen, your common sense is invaluable. Mr. Moncrieff, kindly answer me the following question. Why did you pretend to be my guardian's brother?

Algernon: In order that I might have an opportunity of meeting you.

Cecily: [To Gwendolen.] That certainly seems a satisfactory explanation, does it not?

Gwendolen: Yes, dear, if you can believe him.

Cecily: I don't. But that does not affect the wonderful beauty of his answer.

> **Gwendolen:** True. In matters of grave importance, style, not sincerity is the vital thing. Mr. Worthing, what explanation can you offer to me for pretending to have a brother? Was it in order that you might have an opportunity of coming up to town to see me as often as possible?
>
> **Jack:** Can you doubt it, Miss Fairfax?
>
> **Gwendolen:** I have the gravest doubts upon the subject. But I intend to crush them. This is not the moment for German scepticism. [Moving to Cecily.] Their explanations appear to be quite satisfactory, especially Mr. Worthing's. That seems to me to have the stamp of truth upon it.
>
> **Cecily:** I am more than content with what Mr. Moncrieff said. His voice alone inspires one with absolute credulity.
>
> **Gwendolen:** Then you think we should forgive them?
>
> **Cecily:** Yes. I mean no.
>
> **Gwendolen:** True! I had forgotten. There are principles at stake that one cannot surrender. Which of us should tell them? The task is not a pleasant one.
>
> **Cecily:** Could we not both speak at the same time?
>
> **Gwendolen:** An excellent idea! I nearly always speak at the same time as other people. Will you take the time from me?
>
> **Cecily:** Certainly. [Gwendolen beats time with uplifted finger.]
>
> **Gwendolen and Cecily:** [Speaking together.] Your Christian names are still an insuperable barrier. That is all!
>
> **Jack and Algernon:** [Speaking together.] Our Christian names! Is that all? But we are going to be christened this afternoon.
>
> **Gwendolen:** [To Jack.] For my sake you are prepared to do this terrible thing?
>
> **Jack:** I am.
>
> **Cecily:** [To Algernon.] To please me you are ready to face this fearful ordeal?
>
> **Algernon:** I am!
>
> **Gwendolen:** How absurd to talk of the equality of the sexes! Where questions of self-sacrifice are concerned, men are infinitely beyond us.
>
> **Jack:** We are. [Clasps hands with Algernon.]
>
> **Cecily:** They have moments of physical courage of which we women know absolutely nothing.
>
> **Gwendolen:** [To Jack.] Darling!
>
> **Algernon:** [To Cecily.] Darling! [They fall into each other's arms.]
>
> *[Enter Merriman. When he enters he coughs loudly, seeing the situation.]*
>
> **Merriman:** Ahem! Ahem! Lady Bracknell!
>
> **Jack:** Good heavens!

Passage-based: What do you think makes this moment in the play so delightfully absurd? Support your ideas with details from Wilde's writing.

Alternative: In what ways do you think Wilde makes Algernon such an amusing character?

Look for. "Dignified silence" broken at once; style over sincerity; speaking in unison with a beaten time; christening as "self-sacrifice"; Merriman's cough and Lady Bracknell's arrival.

P11 Act III III.90–106 0486/11/M/J/13

Passage: from "Untruthful! My nephew Algernon? Impossible! He is an Oxonian." to "…drawing herself up.] You must be quite aware that what you propose is out of the question."

> **Lady Bracknell:** Untruthful! My nephew Algernon? Impossible! He is an Oxonian.
>
> **Jack:** I fear there can be no possible doubt about the matter. This afternoon during my temporary absence in London on an important question of romance, he obtained admission to my house by means of the false pretence of being my brother. Under an assumed name he drank, I've just been informed by my butler, an entire pint bottle of my Perrier-

> Jouet, Brut, '89; wine I was specially reserving for myself. Continuing his disgraceful deception, he succeeded in the course of the afternoon in alienating the affections of my only ward. He subsequently stayed to tea, and devoured every single muffin. And what makes his conduct all the more heartless is, that he was perfectly well aware from the first that I have no brother, that I never had a brother, and that I don't intend to have a brother, not even of any kind. I distinctly told him so myself yesterday afternoon.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** Ahem! Mr. Worthing, after careful consideration I have decided entirely to overlook my nephew's conduct to you.
>
> **Jack:** That is very generous of you, Lady Bracknell. My own decision, however, is unalterable. I decline to give my consent.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** [To Cecily.] Come here, sweet child. [Cecily goes over.] How old are you, dear?
>
> **Cecily:** Well, I am really only eighteen, but I always admit to twenty when I go to evening parties.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** You are perfectly right in making some slight alteration. Indeed, no woman should ever be quite accurate about her age. It looks so calculating . . . [In a meditative manner.] Eighteen, but admitting to twenty at evening parties. Well, it will not be very long before you are of age and free from the restraints of tutelage. So I don't think your guardian's consent is, after all, a matter of any importance.
>
> **Jack:** Pray excuse me, Lady Bracknell, for interrupting you again, but it is only fair to tell you that according to the terms of her grandfather's will Miss Cardew does not come legally of age till she is thirty-five.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** That does not seem to me to be a grave objection. Thirty-five is a very attractive age. London society is full of women of the very highest birth who have, of their own free choice, remained thirty-five for years. Lady Dumbleton is an instance in point. To my own knowledge she has been thirty-five ever since she arrived at the age of forty, which was many years ago now. I see no reason why our dear Cecily should not be even still more attractive at the age you mention than she is at present. There will be a large accumulation of property.
>
> **Cecily:** Algy, could you wait for me till I was thirty-five?
>
> **Algernon:** Of course I could, Cecily. You know I could.
>
> **Cecily:** Yes, I felt it instinctively, but I couldn't wait all that time. I hate waiting even five minutes for anybody. It always makes me rather cross. I am not punctual myself, I know, but I do like punctuality in others, and waiting, even to be married, is quite out of the question.
>
> **Algernon:** Then what is to be done, Cecily?
>
> **Cecily:** I don't know, Mr. Moncrieff.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** My dear Mr. Worthing, as Miss Cardew states positively that she cannot wait till she is thirty-five—a remark which I am bound to say seems to me to show a somewhat impatient nature—I would beg of you to reconsider your decision.
>
> **Jack:** But my dear Lady Bracknell, the matter is entirely in your own hands. The moment you consent to my marriage with Gwendolen, I will most gladly allow your nephew to form an alliance with my ward.
>
> **Lady Bracknell:** [Rising and drawing herself up.] You must be quite aware that what you propose is out of the question.

Passage-based: How does Wilde make this such a delightfully comic moment in the play?

Alternative: How far do you think Gwendolen's personality resembles that of her mother? Support your ideas with details from Wilde's writing.

Look for. Jack's list of grievances ending in muffins; age and "calculating" accuracy; thirty-five as an attractive age; Cecily's impatience; the stalemate of mutual consent.

P12 Act III III.152–181 0486/13/O/N/13

Passage: from "Lady Bracknell, I hate to seem inquisitive, but would you kindly inform me who I am?" to "…ta, I've now realised for the first time in my life the vital Importance of Being Earnest."

> **Jack:** Lady Bracknell, I hate to seem inquisitive, but would you kindly inform me who I am?

Lady Bracknell: I am afraid that the news I have to give you will not altogether please you. You are the son of my poor sister, Mrs. Moncrieff, and consequently Algernon's elder brother.

Jack: Algy's elder brother! Then I have a brother after all. I knew I had a brother! I always said I had a brother! Cecily,—how could you have ever doubted that I had a brother? [Seizes hold of Algernon.] Dr. Chasuble, my unfortunate brother. Miss Prism, my unfortunate brother. Gwendolen, my unfortunate brother. Algy, you young scoundrel, you will have to treat me with more respect in the future. You have never behaved to me like a brother in all your life.

Algernon: Well, not till to-day, old boy, I admit. I did my best, however, though I was out of practice.

[Shakes hands.]

Gwendolen: [To Jack.] My own! But what own are you? What is your Christian name, now that you have become some one else?

Jack: Good heavens! . . . I had quite forgotten that point. Your decision on the subject of my name is irrevocable, I suppose?

Gwendolen: I never change, except in my affections.

Cecily: What a noble nature you have, Gwendolen!

Jack: Then the question had better be cleared up at once. Aunt Augusta, a moment. At the time when Miss Prism left me in the hand-bag, had I been christened already?

Lady Bracknell: Every luxury that money could buy, including christening, had been lavished on you by your fond and doting parents.

Jack: Then I was christened! That is settled. Now, what name was I given? Let me know the worst.

Lady Bracknell: Being the eldest son you were naturally christened after your father.

Jack: [Irritably.] Yes, but what was my father's Christian name?

Lady Bracknell: [Meditatively.] I cannot at the present moment recall what the General's Christian name was. But I have no doubt he had one. He was eccentric, I admit. But only in later years. And that was the result of the Indian climate, and marriage, and indigestion, and other things of that kind.

Jack: Algy! Can't you recollect what our father's Christian name was?

Algernon: My dear boy, we were never even on speaking terms. He died before I was a year old.

Jack: His name would appear in the Army Lists of the period, I suppose, Aunt Augusta?

Lady Bracknell: The General was essentially a man of peace, except in his domestic life. But I have no doubt his name would appear in any military directory.

Jack: The Army Lists of the last forty years are here. These delightful records should have been my constant study. [Rushes to bookcase and tears the books out.] M. Generals . . . Mallam, Maxbohm, Magley, what ghastly names they have —Markby, Migsby, Mobbs, Moncrieff! Lieutenant 1840, Captain, Lieutenant-Colonel, Colonel, General 1869, Christian names, Ernest John. [Puts book very quietly down and speaks quite calmly.] I always told you, Gwendolen, my name was Ernest, didn't I? Well, it is Ernest after all. I mean it naturally is Ernest.

Lady Bracknell: Yes, I remember now that the General was called Ernest, I knew I had some particular reason for disliking the name.

Gwendolen: Ernest! My own Ernest! I felt from the first that you could have no other name!

Jack: Gwendolen, it is a terrible thing for a man to find out suddenly that all his life he has been speaking nothing but the truth. Can you forgive me?

Gwendolen: I can. For I feel that you are sure to change.

Jack: My own one!

Chasuble: [To Miss Prism.] Lætitia! [Embraces her]

Miss Prism: [Enthusiastically.] Frederick! At last!

Algernon: Cecily! [Embraces her.] At last!

Jack: Gwendolen! [Embraces her.] At last!

Lady Bracknell: My nephew, you seem to be displaying signs of triviality.

> **Jack:** On the contrary, Aunt Augusta, I've now realised for the first time in my life the vital Importance of Being Earnest.

Passage-based: What do you think makes the end of the play so hilarious? Support your views with details from Wilde's writing.

Alternative: Explore the ways in which Wilde ridicules aspects of upper-class society in The Importance of Being Earnest.

Look for. Repeated "my unfortunate brother"; christening as a luxury; the Army Lists search; the triple "At last!"; the final pun.

Self-test

Twelve quick questions on the facts of the plot. Answers, with references, follow.

1. **Where was Jack found as a baby?**
   In a basket at Worthing station / In a hand-bag in the cloak-room at Victoria Station, the Brighton line / In a perambulator in Bayswater / In the Albany
2. **Who reveals the inscription on the cigarette case?**
   Algernon / Gwendolen / Lady Bracknell / Lane
3. **What does Jack say killed his brother Ernest?**
   A fall in Shropshire / A severe chill in Paris / Apoplexy in Paris / Influenza in London
4. **What changes Lady Bracknell's view of Cecily?**
   Her family solicitors / Her profile / Her three addresses / Learning she has about £130,000 in the Funds
5. **According to her grandfather's will, when does Cecily come of age?**
   Eighteen / Thirty-five / Twenty / Twenty-one
6. **What was in the perambulator when it was found?**
   A baby girl / A hand-bag / Nothing at all / The manuscript of a three-volume novel
7. **Whom does Jack first take to be his mother?**
   Lady Bloxham / Lady Bracknell / Miss Prism / Mrs. Moncrieff
8. **What are Jack's father's Christian names?**
   Ernest Algernon / Ernest John / John Ernest / Thomas Ernest
9. **Which food do Jack and Algernon fight over at the end of Act II?**
   Bread and butter / Cake / Cucumber sandwiches / Muffins
10. **Who says "In matters of grave importance, style, not sincerity is the vital thing"?**
    Algernon / Cecily / Gwendolen / Lady Bracknell
11. **Where is Jack's country house?**
    Belgrave Square / Shropshire / The Manor House, Woolton, Hertfordshire / Tunbridge Wells
12. **On what date did Cecily "accept" Ernest?**
    14 February / 22 March / Her eighteenth birthday / The previous Thursday

Answers

1. In a hand-bag in the cloak-room at Victoria Station, the Brighton line I.211
2. Algernon I.68
3. A severe chill in Paris II.106
4. Learning she has about £130,000 in the Funds III.70
5. Thirty-five III.97
6. The manuscript of a three-volume novel III.126
7. Miss Prism III.148
8. Ernest John III.170

9. Muffins II.393
10. Gwendolen III.19
11. The Manor House, Woolton, Hertfordshire I.274
12. 14 February II.216

Glossary

Bunburying	Algernon's word for inventing a person as an excuse to escape obligations I.88. Play text
The Albany	Jack's town address on his card I.70; a set of gentlemen's chambers in London. Play text; CliffsNotes glossary
Egeria	Chasuble's compliment to Miss Prism, which he calls "a classical allusion" II.30. In Roman legend Egeria was the nymph who advised King Numa: a wise counsellor. Play text; CliffsNotes glossary (see Corrections)
Gorgon	Jack's name for Lady Bracknell I.221: a monster of Greek myth. Jack admits he does not know what one looks like. Play text
Lorgnette	Glasses on a handle, used by Gwendolen to inspect Cecily II.269. CliffsNotes glossary
Perambulator / basinette	A pram and the cradle part of it III.127. CliffsNotes glossary
Anabaptists	A Protestant group associated with adult baptism; Chasuble accuses Jack of their "heretical views" III.115. CliffsNotes glossary
Oxonian	A member or graduate of Oxford University III.90. CliffsNotes glossary
Temperance beverage	A non-alcoholic drink; one exploded in Miss Prism's bag III.145. CliffsNotes glossary
Terminus	The end of a railway line; Lady Bracknell's pun on Jack's origin III.61. CliffsNotes glossary; play text

Sources

- Oscar Wilde, *The Importance of Being Earnest: A Trivial Comedy for Serious People*, Project Gutenberg eBook #844 (2006). The reference text for all quotations and line numbers.
- Cambridge International, *Cambridge IGCSE Literature in English 0475: Syllabus for 2028, 2029 and 2030*; and the 0475 syllabus for 2027 (checked for the set-text list).
- Past-paper questions on the play, IGCSE 0486 (2013).
- LitCharts, *The Importance of Being Earnest* (LitCharts LLC, 2020).
- SparkNotes, *The Importance of Being Earnest* (Spark Publishing, 2014).
- Susan Van Kirk, *CliffsNotes on Wilde's The Importance of Being Earnest* (Wiley, 2004).